

BUSTLING BUSTLETON

Small area neighborhood plan for a Far Northeast Community.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Bustleton, a predominantly residential neighborhood in the Far Northeast of Philadelphia, is neither a city nor a suburb, as local resident and leader Jack O'Hara, observes. With most of the acreage occupied by single-family detached homes on mid-century curvilinear streets, Bustleton is a part of Philadelphia and has been since 1854. This small area plan centers around the local-serving commercial corridor of Bustleton Avenue. With an overall vision to reimagine the area as a place where all residents have greater access to the benefits of the existing neighborhood, this plan lays out a series of recommendations that leverage the community's own assets with city programming and other resources to turn this vision into a reality over the next decade.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

We would like to express our thanks and appreciation to the following people who were instrumental in putting together this small area plan. We would not have gained as in-depth an understanding of Bustleton without the opportunity to speak with long-time resident and Greater Bustleton Civic League President, Jack O'Hara, who so generously lent us his time. We also greatly appreciated getting to talk to Tom Whitworth, Far Northeast resident and family friend of our team member, Matt Hilferty. Finally, we are especially grateful to our instructor, Ellie Devyatkin, for all her unwavering support, and sharp guidance throughout the semester.



FIG.1 PHOTO OF BUSTLETON STUDIO PLANNING GROUP

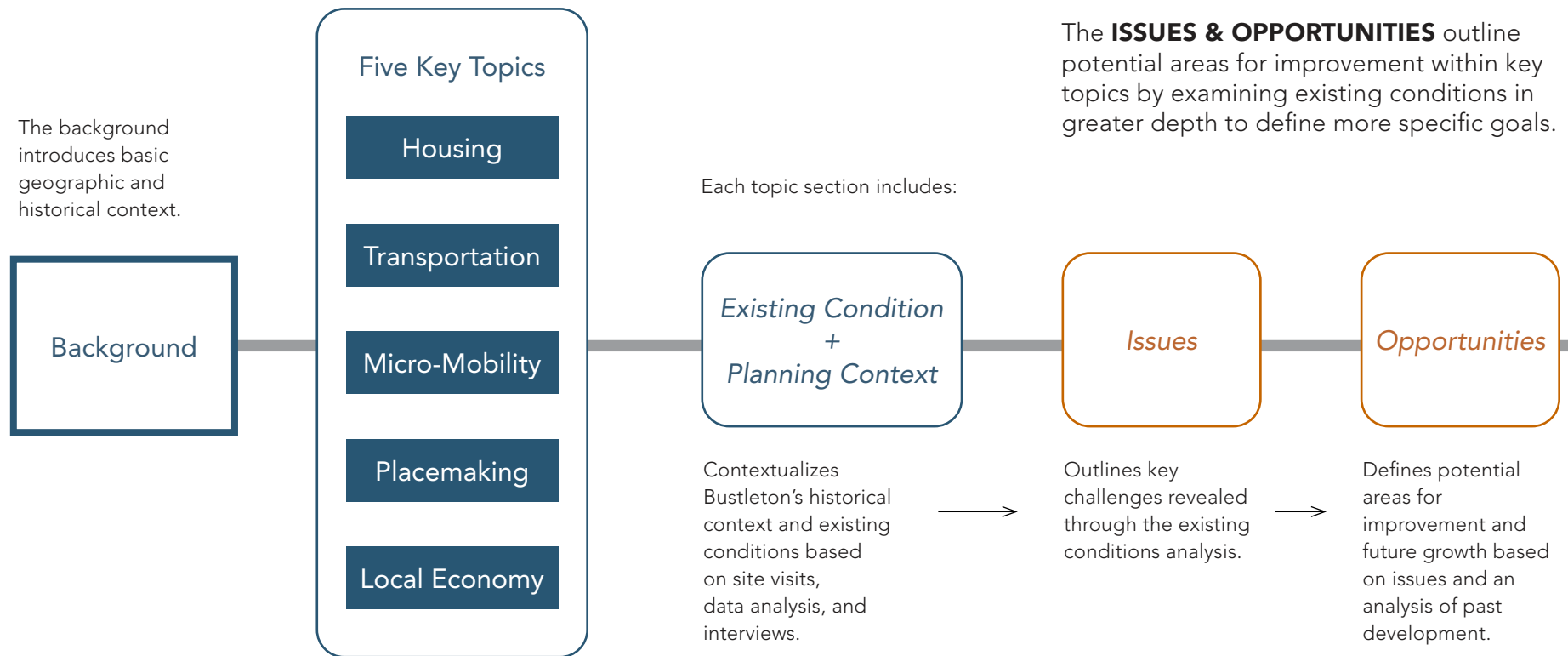
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Plan Structure

The plan traces Bustleton’s history to where it stands today, exploring the choices, goals, and actions that can shape where it goes next.

The **INTRODUCTION** identifies key topics by examining Bustleton’s history and existing conditions, helping the area maintain its strengths while exploring future opportunities.



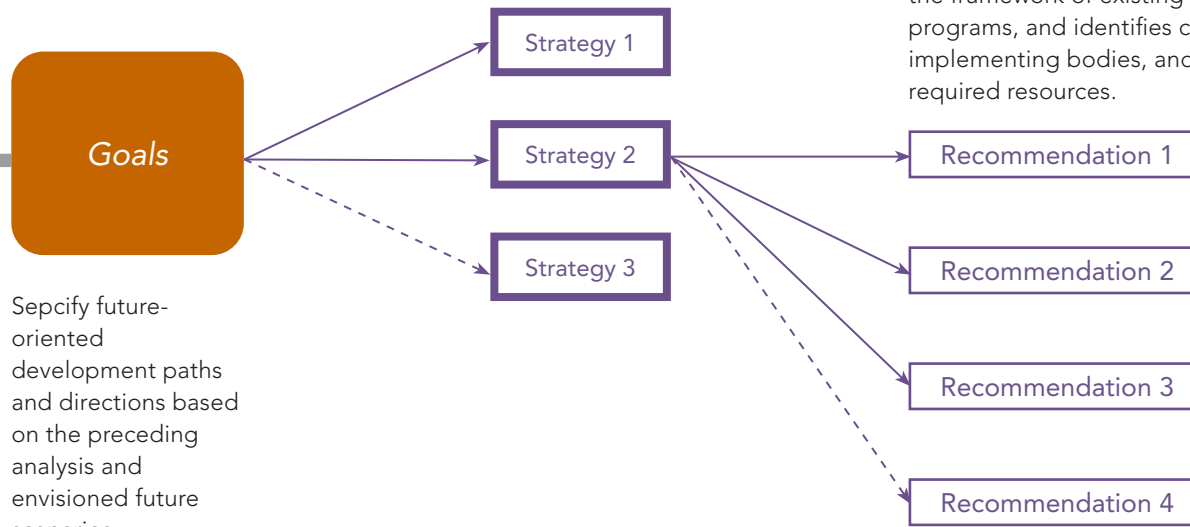
The **STRATEGY & RECOMMENDATION** specifies how to advance the vision and goals. It elaborates on the specific strategies and recommendations that respond to multiple goals.

A Goal is a direction that describes a desired outcome in relation to the five identified topics.

A Strategy is a specific approach or method to accomplish one or more desired outcomes. Strategies are broad and consist of multiple recommendations.

A Recommendation introduces a directive for the successful implementation of the strategy and the corresponding goals. It is developed using the framework of existing programs, and identifies cost, implementing bodies, and the required resources.

IMPLEMENTATION moves recommendations from plan to practice. Each recommendation includes an implementation sidebar detailing priority, lead entity, cost, goal alignment, and timeline to guide phased rollout and resource allocation.

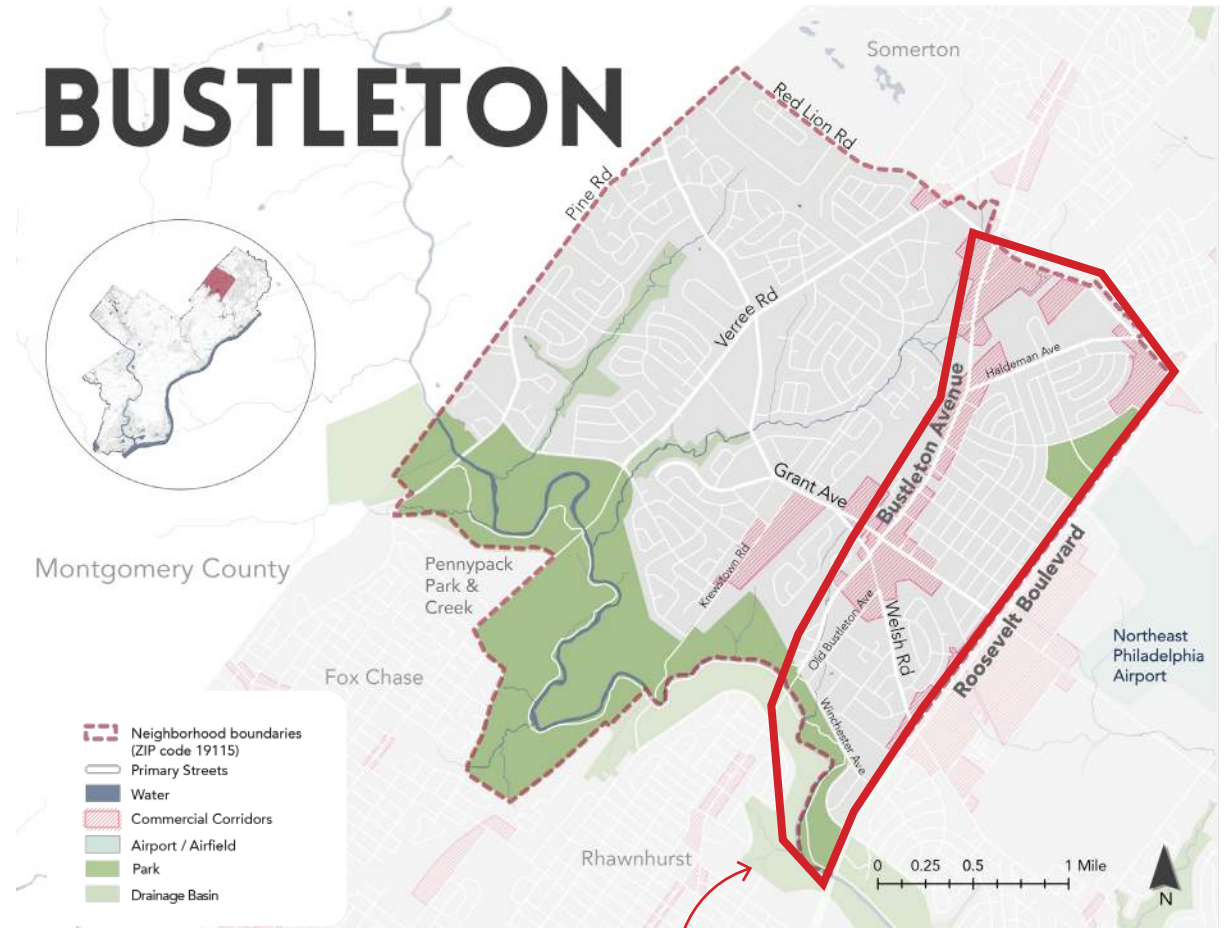


Specify future-oriented development paths and directions based on the preceding analysis and envisioned future scenarios.



Background

Bustleton sits in the Far Northeast section of Philadelphia, nestled on the northern edge of Pennypack Park and Creek. With its western border defined by the county line along Pine Road, the large arterial, Roosevelt Boulevard, serves as another clear eastern border on the other side. Under the 19115 zip code boundaries, Bustleton extends as far northward as Red Lion Road, beyond which the nearby Somerton begins. At 13.5 miles away from Philadelphia's City Hall, Bustleton belongs to a group of Philadelphia neighborhoods that are far removed from the city center. Despite this geographic distance from the hubs of downtown Philadelphia, Bustleton is home to several active commercial corridors along the area's main roadways of Bustleton Avenue, Grant Avenue, Red Lion Road and Roosevelt Boulevard. Indeed, the corridor area is this sub-section of the neighborhood that this plan devotes its primary analysis and recommendations towards.



Focus Area

Once part of Lower Dublin Township, Bustleton was incorporated into the City of Philadelphia in 1854 [1]. Prior to the 20th century, Bustleton was predominantly agrarian and sparsely populated. The smaller town center developed around hotels and taverns like the Bustleton Hotel which sat at the intersection of Bustleton Avenue and Welsh Road, in what is today the southeastern corner of Bustleton [2].

The new era ushered in by the end of the second world war had a lasting effect on the cultural and physical character of the neighborhood. During this period,

Bustleton, along with the rest of the Far Northeast, became a prime location for suburban development, spurred by greater consumer financing options made available through federal policy like the Lanham Defense Act and the GI Bill [3]. By the mid-1950s, Bustleton's path towards a middle-class suburbia was well cemented as Philadelphia's then City Planning Commissioner, Edmund Bacon, promoted further suburban residential growth and construction of auto-

oriented shopping centers in his 1955 plan for the Northeast [2].

At the same time, Bustleton became increasingly integrated and connected to central Philadelphia as well as surrounding regions. In the early 20th century,

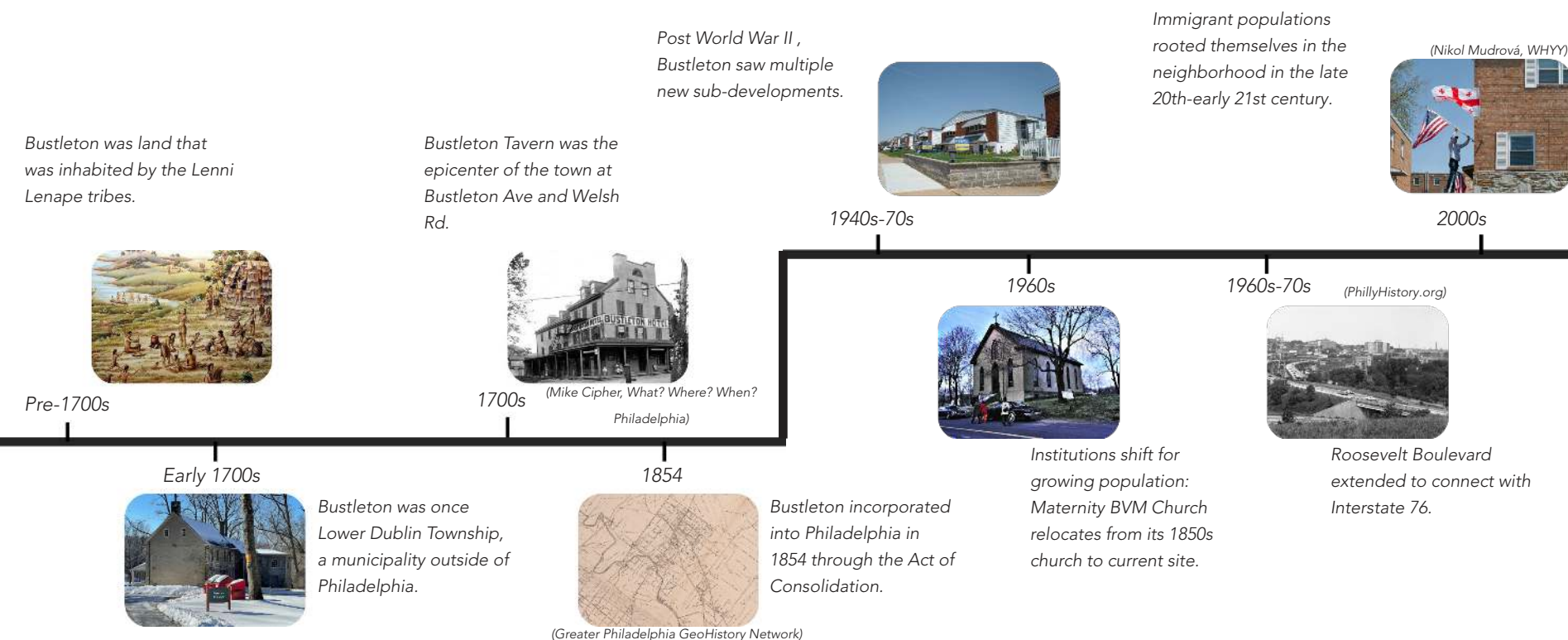




FIG.1 GROWING POPULATION IN BUSTLETON

a Far Northeast trolley connected Bustleton with Frankford Transportation Center, with its terminus just behind the Tavern and Inn. Between the 60s and 70s, Roosevelt Boulevard was extended to connect with I-76, expanding access to Philadelphia and its surrounding counties.

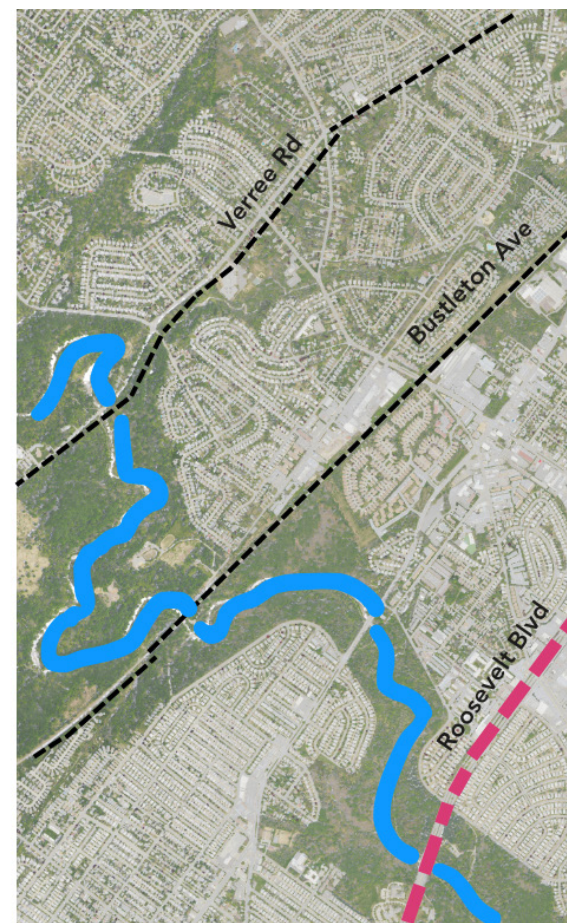
In conjunction with these ongoing trends of increasing urban and regional connection and residential subdevelopments, Bustleton experienced a mid-century population boom, in large part due to returning World War II veterans. As this trend began to plateau by the 1970s, the neighborhood saw continued growth as new immigrant diaspora from the post-Soviet regions of Eastern Europe and Central Asia began to settle in the area towards the end of the 20th and early 21st century.

These historical origins of Bustleton, and its more contemporary history in particular, have played a significant role in shaping the appearance and feel of Bustleton today – a low-density neighborhood characterized by single-family residences on quiet cul-de-sac streets, branching off from the neighborhood's car-centric commercial corridors. These are lined by shopping centers, most accessed by one's personal vehicle rather than public transit.



1950

FIG.2 PENNSYLVANIA GEOLOGICAL SURVEY. (1950). PENNPILOT HISTORICAL AERIAL PHOTO LIBRARY [AERIAL PHOTOGRAPH]. PENNSYLVANIA SPATIAL DATA ACCESS (PASDA), PENN STATE UNIVERSITY.



2022

FIG.3 U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE, FARM SERVICE AGENCY. (2022). NATIONAL AGRICULTURE IMAGERY PROGRAM (NAIP): PENNSYLVANIA 2022 [AERIAL ORTHOIMAGERY]. PENNSYLVANIA SPATIAL DATA ACCESS (PASDA).



Bustleton is a family-oriented, international community in the Far Northeast of Philadelphia with a substantial aging population. It is a predominantly white and middle-income neighborhood, but the share of Asian and black or African American population in the neighborhood has grown in recent years, contributing to an increasingly diverse community.

Demographics

Age groups & race/ethnicity

Bustleton's population is more mature than Philadelphia. The median age is 44 years old, nearly ten years older than Philadelphia's median age of 35. We also observe, based on the age distribution, that approximately a quarter of residents in Bustleton are 65 years old or older.

Bustleton is also a family neighborhood, where nearly half of all households are occupied by married couples. Nearly 20% of these households are also home to

children of the householder who are under the age of 18. Furthermore, close to 20% of all residents are under 18. This population is largely supported by six elementary and middle schools within the neighborhood boundaries; the public high school is located just outside the ZIP code.

Over the past decade, while still a predominantly white neighborhood, Bustleton is becoming an increasingly diverse community. Recently, this has been driven by the growing Asian community, and a slight increase in the black or African American population since 2014. Specifically, the Asian share in the neighborhood grew by 10 percentage points, while the black or African American population grew by 4 percentage points where each represents around 20% and 10% of

the total population in 2024, respectively. While the share of the Hispanic or Latino community did not increase substantially from 2014 to 2024, it is also worth noting that the neighborhood is home to nearly 2,400 individuals (7%) who identify as Hispanic or Latino.

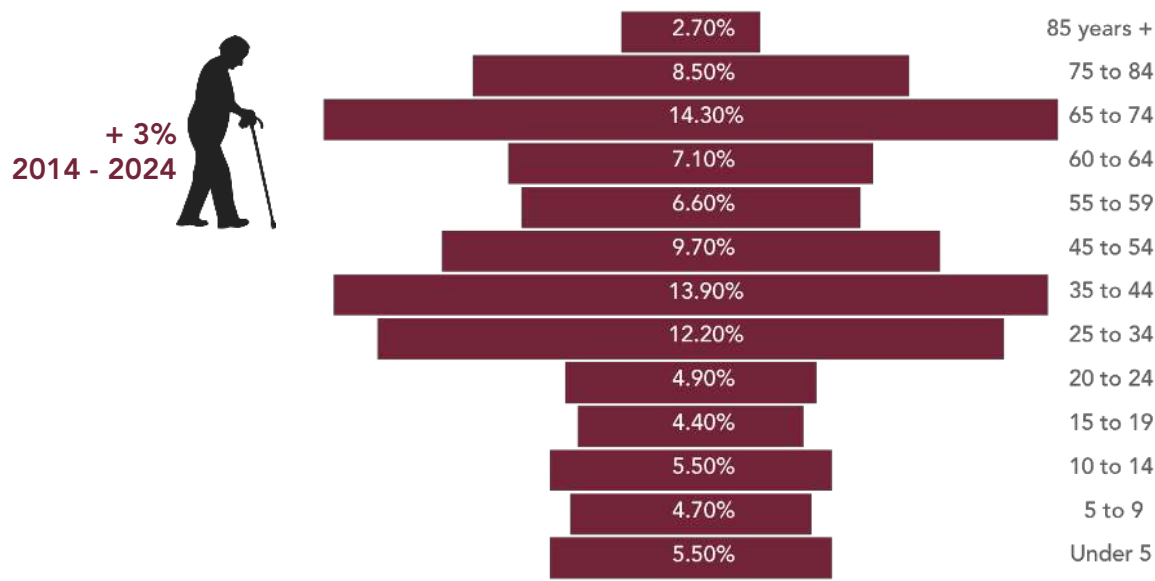


FIG.4 POPULATION PYRAMID

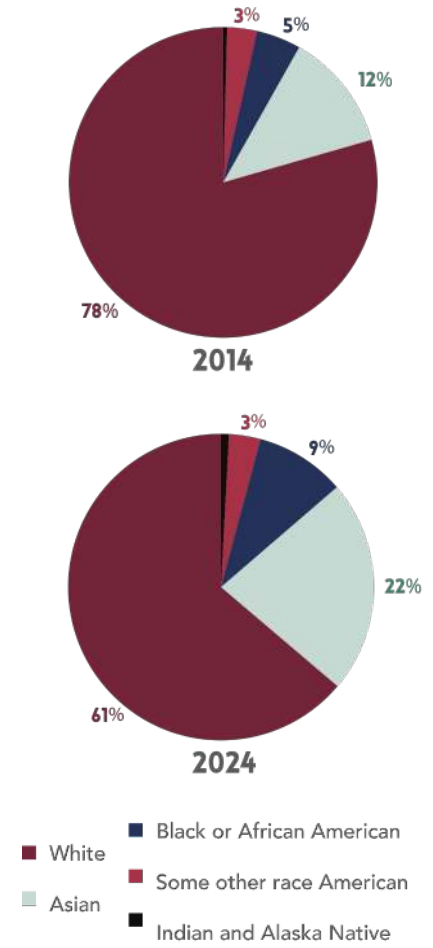


FIG.5 RACIAL DISTRIBUTION

International Community

The population breakdown by race partially obscures the particularly international character of the neighborhood. In contrast to the rest of Philadelphia, over one-third of the population were born outside of the U.S. Of these individuals, 38% were born in an Eastern European country – the most prevalent of which are Ukraine, Albania and Russia. Meanwhile, another third were born in South Central Asian countries, including India, Uzbekistan, and what the U.S. Census Bureau categorizes as ‘Other South Central Asia’ (i.e., Kazakhstan or Turkmenistan).

This international identity is reflected in the plethora of languages primarily spoken at home besides English. Since 2014, fewer households report English as the primary language spoken at home, likely driven by an increase in those who speak a language that belongs to ‘Asian and Pacific Islander’ census category, as seen in Figure #. This category of languages can include Telugu, Tamil and Malayalam as well as Chinese and Uzbek, among many others.

Indo-European languages are also prevalent languages spoken at home. This category includes a range of languages from French and Italian, to Russian, Ukrainian and other Slavic languages among others. Based on observations gathered from several site visits, we highlight Russian, Ukrainian, Georgian, and Uzbek as among the more common languages which can be encountered in the neighborhood.

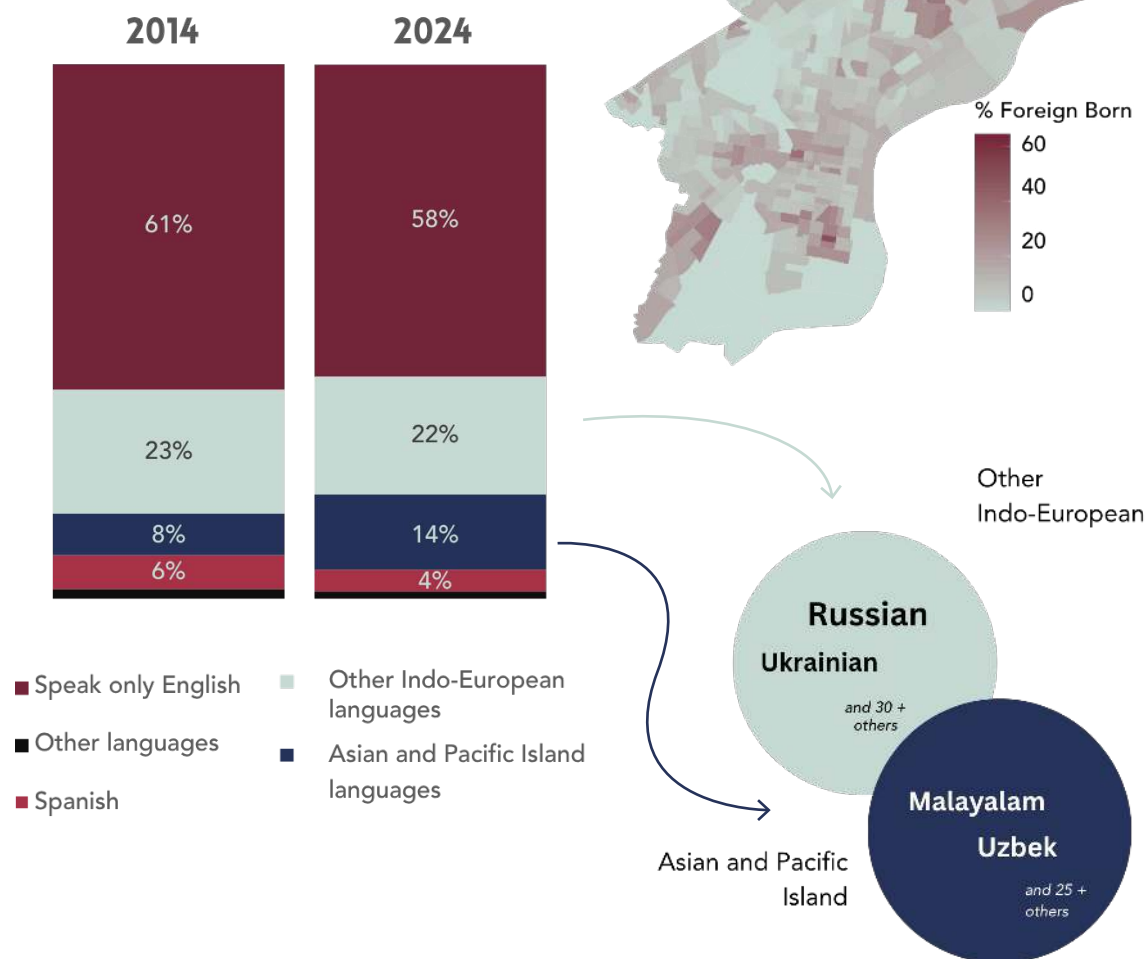


FIG.7 PRIMARY LANGUAGE SPOKEN AT HOME

Socioeconomic Factors

Beyond these demographic characteristics, Bustleton residents hold a relatively more prosperous socioeconomic position compared to the average Philadelphian, with higher levels of educational attainment and moderate incomes. Changes over the last decade indicate that some residents' socioeconomic positions are shifting farther upwards. This is experienced disparately, however, leaving behind some Bustleton residents, particularly the renters within a homeowner-dominant community.

Income

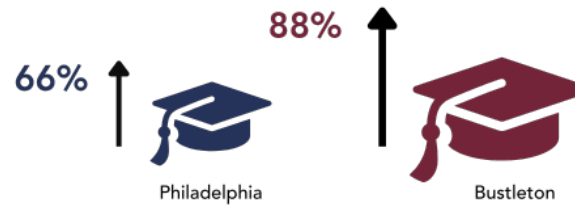
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Education

Overall, the education attainment levels of Bustleton residents are generally consistent with Philadelphia-wide levels.

However, Bustleton noticeably diverges from the city when looking at the rate of increase in the share of residents with graduate or professional degrees (88% vs. 66%) – potentially reflecting some residents' upward social mobility.



Percent increase in the share of residents with graduate or professional degrees

Homeowner Community

Just like the larger city in which it sits, Bustleton is a homeowner-dominant community. Despite this broad commonality, the Bustleton landscape, shaped by the logics of mid-century suburban development, directly impacts how private residential life feels. While much of Philadelphia home-life is centered around the higher density rowhome model, Bustleton's residential areas are more suburban in feel, with greater examples of spacious single-family detached lots with dedicated backyards and quintessential white picket fences.

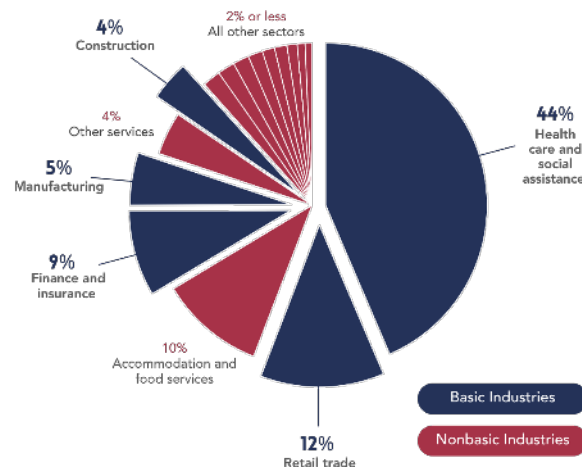


Homeowner and Renter Disparity

While most Bustleton residents are homeowners, nearly 40% of residents are renters. In comparison to their homeowner counterparts, renters are disproportionately cost-burdened. Sixty-two percent of renters in Bustleton are cost-burdened with greater than 30% of their monthly income going towards housing. Meanwhile, the majority of homes in the area are valued between \$300,000 and \$500,000, which further underscores a widening gap between potentially asset-rich homeowners and burdened renters.



FIG.8 DISTRIBUTION OF JOBS BY INDUSTRY SECTOR



Retail trade, along with accommodation, food services, and other consumer-oriented services, collectively accounts for approximately 27% of jobs in Bustleton. These activities are spatially concentrated along major commercial corridors such as Bustleton Avenue and Roosevelt Boulevard, where strip malls host a mix of chain retailers and locally owned businesses. Examples include grocery stores, restaurants, salons, and culturally specific businesses serving South Asian, Eastern European, and Central Asian communities. Despite their continued presence, employment in retail trade declined by 12% between 2013 and 2023, while accommodation and food services experienced a 25% reduction during the same period. These sectors remain closely tied to corridor-based commercial formats, where business visibility and access are shaped by arterial road conditions. The economic health of local businesses is relatively stable and not a huge concern for stewards of the neighborhood like Jack O'Hara, President of the Greater Bustleton Civic League, neighborhood association.

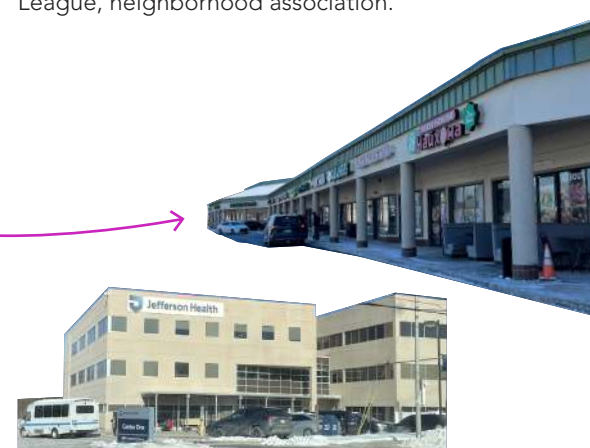
Local Economy

Bustleton's economy is shaped by a dominant health care sector, middle income households, and a workforce that largely commutes outside the neighborhood for higher-wage employment. Retail and service businesses remain present along major corridors but are influenced by aging commercial forms and auto-oriented site design. Besides, diverse local businesses, a growing health care sector, and nearby regional employment centers contribute to ongoing economic activity.

Industry and Employment

Health care and social assistance represent the largest employment sector in Bustleton, accounting for 3,776 jobs, or 44% of total employment.

Over the past decade, this sector has increased its share of total jobs by 12 percentage points between 2013 and 2023. The concentration of employment in this industry exceeds the citywide average, indicating that health care functions as a basic sector within the neighborhood economy. Unlike areas anchored by a major hospital, this employment base is distributed across numerous clinics and satellite facilities affiliated with larger regional providers, including Jefferson Health and Temple Health. These facilities are dispersed throughout the neighborhood and often embedded within commercial corridors, reinforcing their integration into everyday local activity. The prominence of these decentralized medical services reflects the dominant role of outpatient and specialized care facilities in shaping local employment patterns.



Outward Commute

Bustleton exhibits a strong outward commuting pattern. Of 12,664 employed residents, roughly 94% of employed residents leave the neighborhood for work. At the same time, 7,936 workers commute into Bustleton from other areas, which means that most jobs within the neighborhood are filled by non-residents. This distribution highlights a clear separation between residential location and employment opportunities. Approximately 60% of inbound workers originate from North Philadelphia and nearby northern suburbs. Bustleton residents' workplaces are more geographically dispersed, with 55% working in North Philadelphia, the surrounding suburbs, or Center City.

The outward commuting pattern is associated with higher incomes. Over half of Bustleton residents earn more than \$3,333 per month, while only 40% of jobs located within the neighborhood meet that wage level. Citywide, just over 60% of jobs exceed this threshold, indicating that higher-wage employment is less common locally. As a result, residents seeking higher earnings are more likely to commute to employment centers such as Center City, University City, and suburban areas in Northeast Philadelphia.

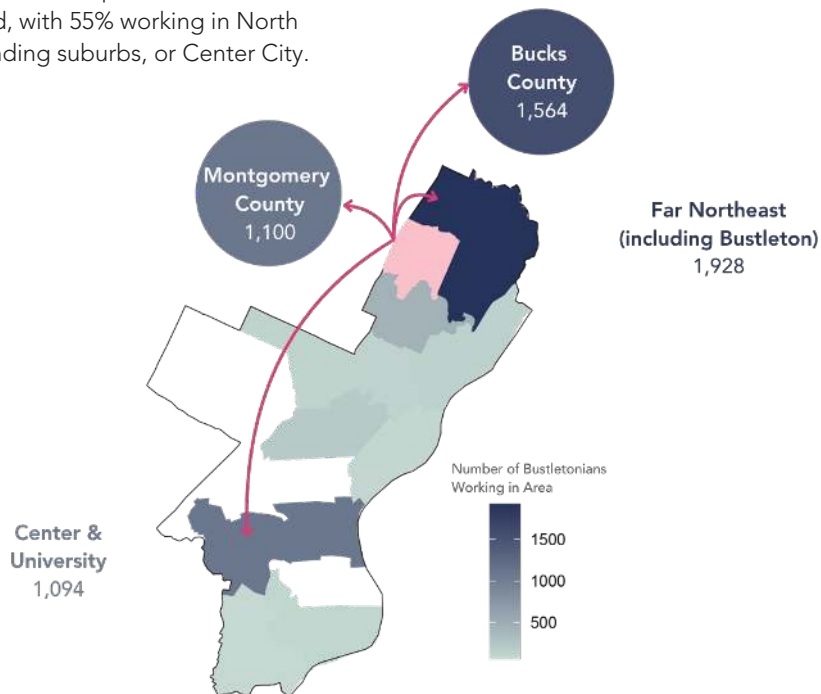


FIG.9 BUSTLETON RESIDENTS' COMMUTE TO WORK

Green Space

Bustleton is home to a range of green spaces, which further reflects the neighborhood's low-density, suburban character. With Pennypack Park on its southern edge and several community parks and recreational areas scattered throughout the neighborhood, these spaces offer respite from busy roads and commercial corridors and the resources for residents to stay active and engaged with other community members.

Pennypack Park and Creek

Part of the Fairmount Park system, Pennypack Park is a culturally important anchor for this section of Northeast Philadelphia. Its name derives from the Leni Lenape term meaning "slow moving water," a reference to the creek that stretches roughly nine miles from Montgomery County to the Delaware River. A network of hiking trails throughout the park connects residents directly to the waterway, offering a natural escape that is unique within Philadelphia's urban context. When calculating the ratio of the total areas of green space to non-green space in the neighborhood, we find a green cover ratio in Bustleton that reaches nearly 70% while Philadelphia's average ratio stands around 31%. Excluding Pennypack Park from this calculation, Bustleton's ratio decreases to 57%, still a substantially greater share of greenery than Philadelphia overall. Several other parks and wooded areas in the neighborhood help contribute to these numbers.

Hayes Woods

Running along Roosevelt Boulevard, Hayes Woods is a woodland tract adjacent to Conwell Park. Like Pennypack, it contains several maintained walking trails surrounded by lush greenery. It stands in stark contrast to the built-up land of single-family suburban development that characterizes much of the surrounding community. Thus, it represents one of the neighborhood's few remaining areas of unmanicured land that serves as a great natural asset for nearby residents.

Conwell Park, Hayes Playground, and Bustleton Fields Complex

Adjacent to Hayes Woods, this large recreational complex was recently renovated through the City of Philadelphia's Rebuild Program and serves as a hub of active community life. The complex offers a broad range of amenities, including playgrounds, indoor and outdoor basketball courts, tennis courts, a splash-ground, and sports fields. It also functions as a home base for local athletic programs, with school teams such as the Bustleton Bengal Tigers making active use of the fields.

Baldi Playground and the William A. Lackman Memorial Playground Bustleton Fields Complex

Located in the more residential western reaches of the neighborhood, Baldi Playground and the William A. Lackman Memorial Playground serve as neighborhood-scale complements to the larger recreational facilities found elsewhere in Bustleton. Lackman Memorial Playground is a particularly active community resource, with a community pool and a variety of programs that cater to residents of all ages.



FIG.10 PENNYPACK TRAIL

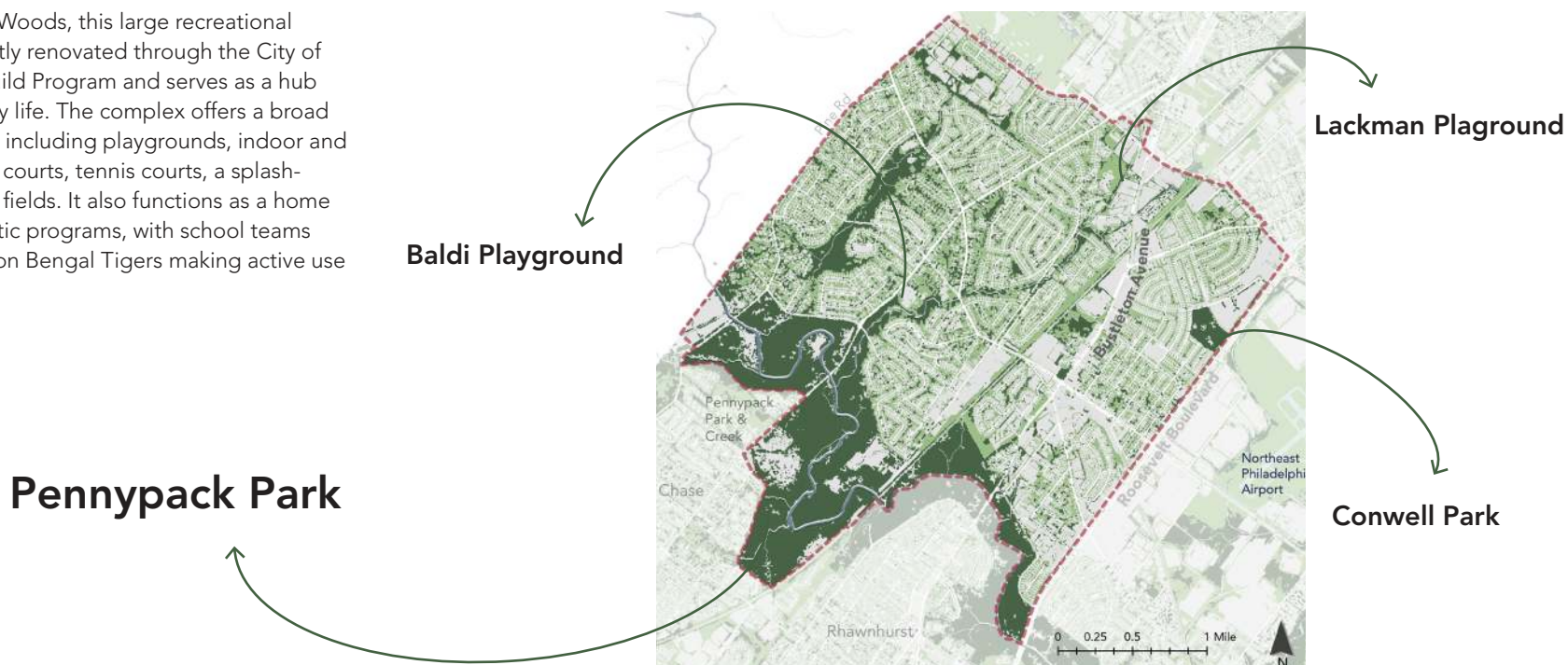


FIG.11 TREE AND SHRUB COVER

Land Use, Zoning and Community Assets

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Land Use

Examining Bustleton's land use pattern further illuminates a neighborhood defined above all else by its suburban residential character. The distribution of uses across the neighborhood, and the regulatory frameworks that govern them, together reinforce a built environment oriented around the single-family home, the personal automobile, and the commercial corridor.

Bustleton is made up of approximately 3,334 acres within ZIP Code 19115, with 59% of developable land used for residential purposes. This land consists primarily of single-family detached and two-family homes arranged in the curvilinear street networks typical of mid-20th-century suburban development – a direct legacy of the postwar building boom described earlier in this plan. Commercial land use accounts for around 7% of the neighborhood and is concentrated along major arterial corridors in auto-

oriented shopping centers. Industrial uses account for approximately 4%, primarily located along the northern edge, buffering residential areas from regional infrastructure. Park and open space represent nearly 20% of land area, though this figure is largely due to Pennypack Park.

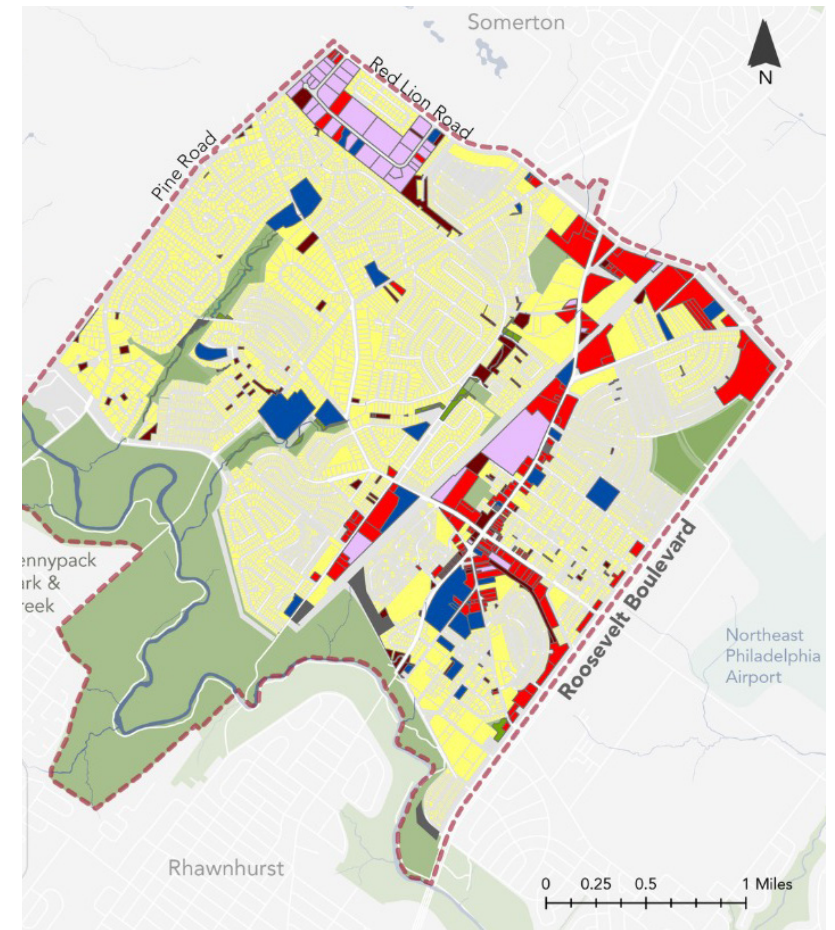


FIG.12 LAND USE MAP

Zoning

Overlapping zoning and environmental controls exist to preserve Bustleton's low-density character and limit development intensity. The Far Northeast and Northeast Zoning Overlays prioritize low-rise structures and automobile-oriented site design that restricts commercial uses to designated corridors and protects interior residential areas. The neighborhood also falls within the Airport Hazard Control District that, through an imposed height ceiling of 200 feet, effectively prevents any form of high-rise development and in turn, a permanent density ceiling. Environmental protections along Pennypack Creek and its tributaries further constrain the developable land base through steep slope regulations and waterfront setbacks that preserve riparian buffers and reduce flood risk.

- Residential Single-Family Attached (RSA)
- Residential Two-Family Attached (RT)
- Residential Two-Family Detached (RSD)
- Residential Multi-Family (RM)
- Residential Mixed-Use (RMX)
- Auto-Oriented Commercial (CA)
- Neighborhood Commercial Mixed-Use (CMX)
- Light Industrial (I1)
- Medium Industrial (I2)
- Parks and Open Space (SPPOA)

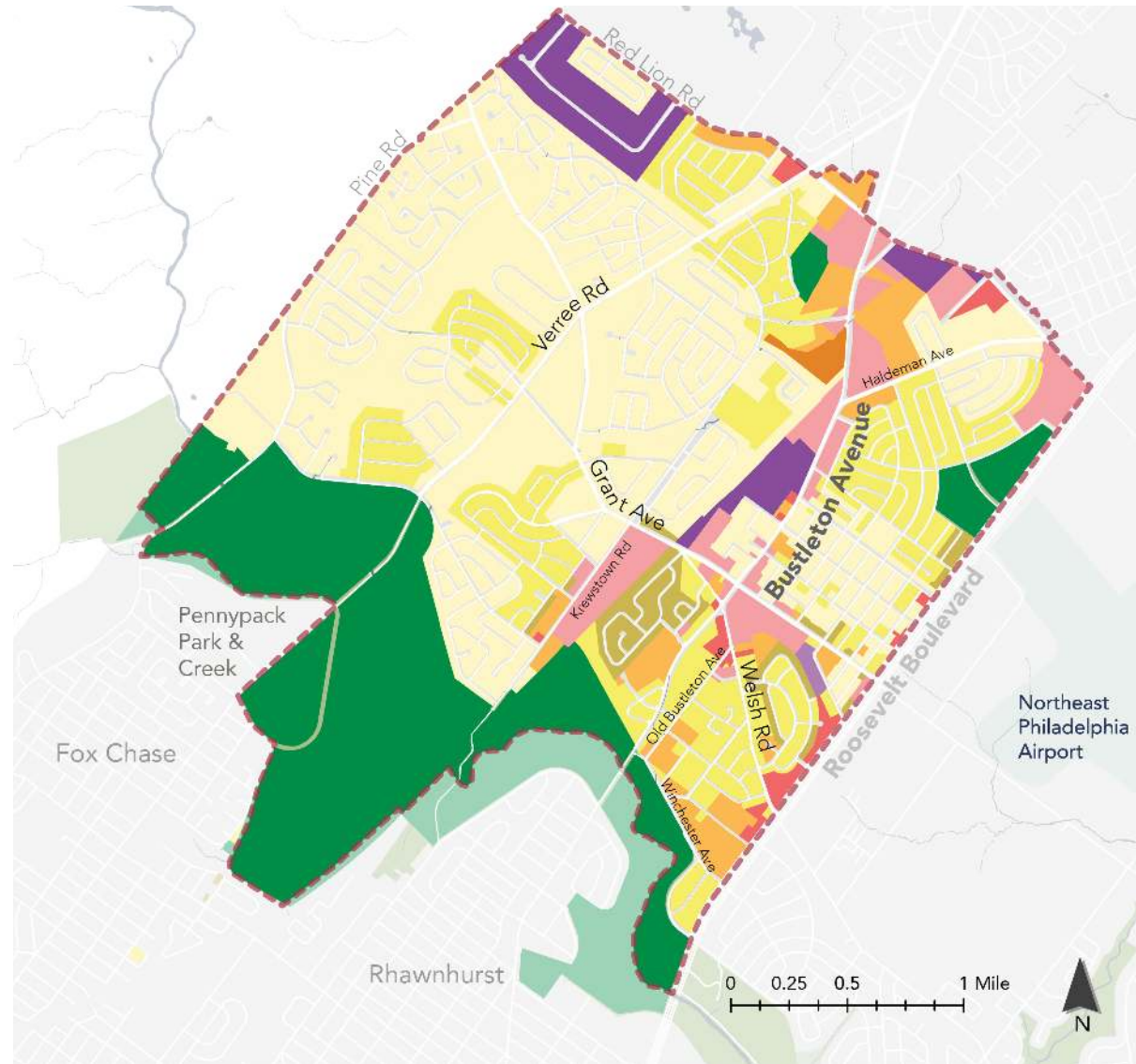


FIG.13 ZONING MAP

Community Assets

Bustleton also supports a well-distributed network of community assets which serve the current residents.

Religious institutions are particularly important community anchors, with eighteen predominantly Christian and Jewish congregations. These provide not only worship space, but social services and gathering places woven throughout the neighborhood. Civic life is organized in part through active neighborhood associations like the Greater Bustleton Civic League, headed by the director and local resident, Jack O'Hara. The New World Association, established and run by Bustleton resident, Marina Lipkovskaya, tailors its services, like English-language courses, to support newly arrived immigrants in the area.

Despite this breadth of assets, access to them is constrained by the auto-oriented street network that shapes so much of Bustleton's character. With heavy reliance on the personal vehicle to move around the neighborhood, individuals without access to a car face greater barriers to benefit and engage with such assets. These challenges are likely felt most acutely by the area's large and growing aging population.



FIG.14 JACK O'HARA, PRESIDENT OF GREATER BUSTLETON CIVIC LEAGUE, WITH SENATOR JIMMY DILLON. KEEP PENNSYLVANIA BEAUTIFUL.

FIG.15 MARINA LIPKOVSKAYA, A DIRECTOR OF NEW WORLD ASSOCIATION, IN ONE OF HER CLASSROOMS FILLED WITH SUPPLIES FOR UKRAINE CREDIT: NIKOL MUDROVÁ



Transportation

Bustleton residents are very car dependent. They have limited access to transit. The Boulevard is a key corridor, but it's dangerous for drivers and pedestrians alike.

Transportation Methods

Transportation in Bustleton is defined overwhelmingly by personal automobiles. While seven bus routes serve the neighborhood, three operate at intervals exceeding 60 minutes, and four run only twice per hour. This includes the Direct Bus line that connects Frankford Transportation Center to the Far Northeast, introduced in 2017 as part of the ongoing Route for Change initiative. As a result, a transit network exists in Bustleton but does not meaningfully compete with the car. An extreme minority of residents commute by transit (6%), compared to 17% citywide. This is especially striking as the vast majority of residents (94%) work outside the neighborhood.

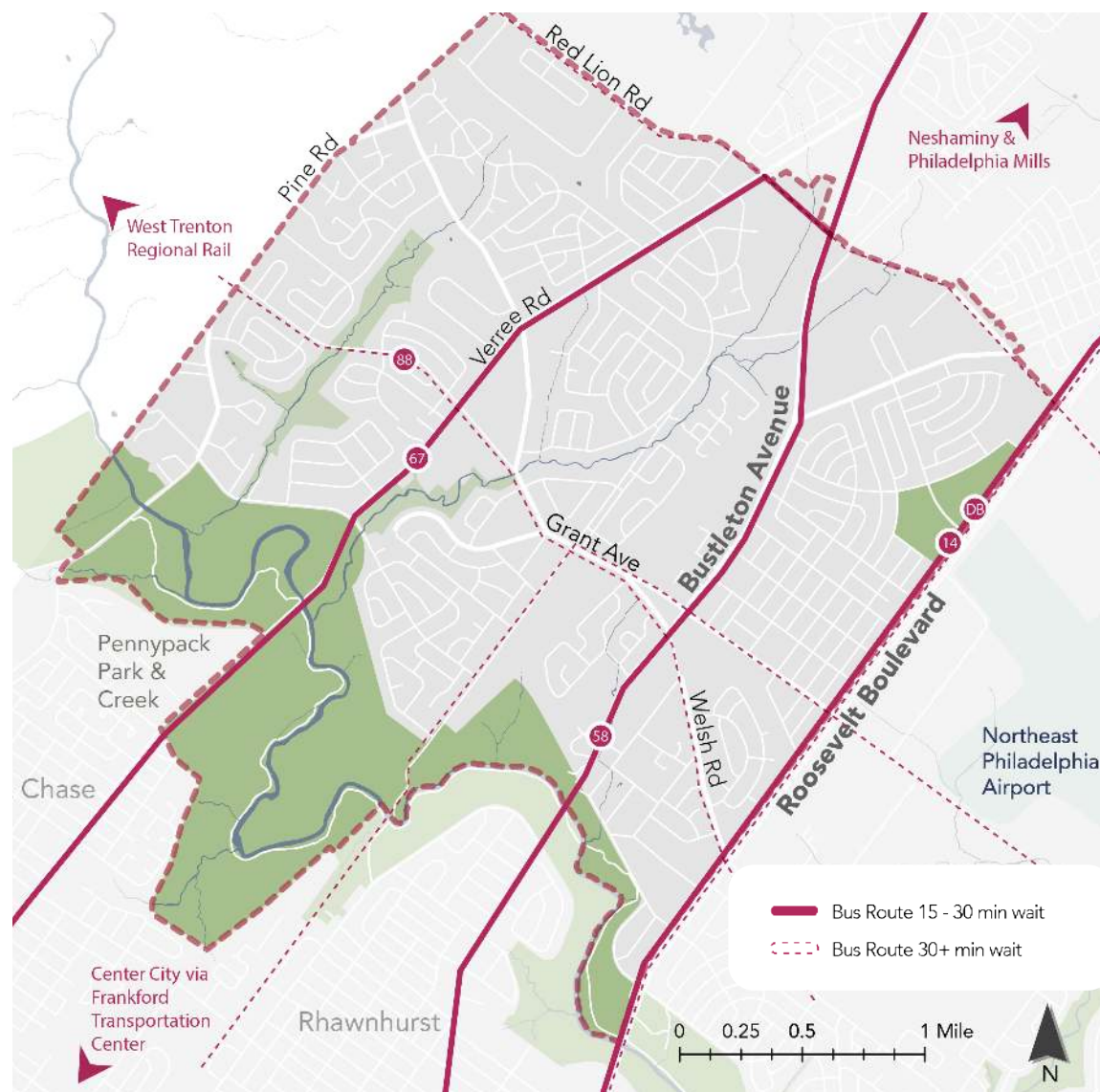
78%

of Bustleton residents commute by car



14%

of Bustleton residents don't own a car



The high level of car ownership reflects this reality where only 14% of Bustleton households do not own a car. Roosevelt Boulevard remains the primary arterial corridor that connects residents to Center City and the Market-Frankford Line. Throughout the Far Northeast, the Boulevard is characterized by twelve lanes divided between inner express lanes, local-access lanes, and separating medians. In Bustleton specifically, the Boulevard narrows, with a reduced center median and no crossover lanes, creating a particularly challenging environment for pedestrians to navigate.

Roosevelt Boulevard

The scale and design of Roosevelt Boulevard has long been recognized as both a considerable infrastructure challenge as well as an opportunity. The Route for Change program, a collaboration between the City of Philadelphia, PennDOT, and SEPTA running from 2016 to 2040, represents the most significant ongoing effort to reimagine the corridor. Thus far, the initiative has implemented early interventions such as the Direct Bus and speed cameras, with further transformation anticipated in the years ahead.

Beyond Roosevelt Boulevard, Bustleton Avenue is another important corridor that serves the community both as a commuter route and as the site of the neighborhood's key local-serving businesses in avenue-adjacent shopping centers. Though it has not received as much attention as the nearby boulevard, it poses similar safety challenges to the community such as frequent speeding and limited infrastructure for pedestrians and cyclists. This topic is discussed in greater detail in the following sections of the plan (see Issues & Opportunities, pg #).



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We seek to enhance opportunities for all Busleton's inhabitants spanning across ages, cultural and racial backgrounds, and socioeconomic levels, encouraging the neighborhood's overall vitality.

Vision

This plan's components – vision, assessment of issues and opportunities, and proposed goals and actionable recommendations – are rooted, first and foremost, in current residents' perceptions and experiences of their neighborhood.

As the GBCL President, Jack O'Hara notes that Bustleton is “not a city, [and] it's not a suburb... it's a combination of the two. It has that suburb-ish feel to it, but it is inside Philadelphia.”. In general terms, long-time residents value the neighborhood, benefiting from its current amenities. This is especially true among the immigrant community in Bustleton. The Far Northeast more broadly is reputed to provide newcomers with a sense of security and belonging. In a 2017 Philadelphia Neighborhoods article, Bustleton resident, Orasta Koshoik, reflects on how she felt able to breathe and more like herself upon arriving in the neighborhood.

“I wasn't able to breathe in New York...I wasn't able to breathe until I came here.”

“I felt like myself back at home.”

These examples speak to the area's strengths enjoyed by many, but its auto-oriented design can still be a challenge for others; in particular, Bustleton aging residents. In March 2026, a serious car accident occurred just outside the neighborhood's bounds on Bustleton Ave. All three individuals involved were over the age of 60, one of whom was a woman struck while walking on the sidewalk. Incidents like these reinforce the Far Northeast District Plan's 2017 assessment: “as the population in the Far Northeast ages, reliance on the automobile may become a barrier for those who wish to age in place.”

The current plan follows from these apparent strengths and weaknesses of Bustleton, in that it does not



to disrupt the existing benefits that local residents consistently speak of, but to enhance opportunities for all its inhabitants of different ages, cultural and racial backgrounds, and socioeconomic levels, encouraging the neighborhood's overall vitality. This framework helps to inform the plan's final vision, goals, and recommendations that follow.

VISION STATEMENT

Bustleton is a multicultural, intergenerational community anchored around a vibrant and thriving Bustleton Ave which is accessible to all.

Goals

The goals of this plan work together to contribute to the vision of the plan, touching on all major aspects of what would potentially impact and contribute to the quality of life of Bustleton residents and making it an inclusive space for all. They address how people move through the neighborhood, where and how they live, what businesses and services they can access, and how connected they feel to the public spaces and natural environment around them. No single goal stands alone; each depends on and reinforces the others.

At their center is a commitment to reinstating Bustleton Avenue as the neighborhood's Main Street, supporting its existing economic vitality while creating the conditions for it to grow, and ensuring that the corridor works for everyone who lives, works, and spends time here.



The challenges Bustleton's residents navigate, the gaps in the built environment and the opportunities that make meaningful change within reach.





Bustleton Housing

Bustleton represents a highly stable, ownership-dominated housing market within Philadelphia's Far Northeast. Its development pattern, rooted in post-war suburban expansion, has produced a neighborhood defined by low density, high homeownership, and long-term residential continuity.

This stability reflects a structurally constrained housing system that limits adaptability in the face of shifting demographic and economic conditions.

The neighborhood offers few options outside of traditional ownership or aging multifamily units. This lack of housing diversity has contributed to affordability pressures, particularly for renters. Despite slightly lower rents compared to the county, high-cost burdens indicate that renter incomes are not keeping pace with housing costs.

Bustleton's housing market is therefore defined by a tension between stability and flexibility. While long-term residents benefit from continuity and asset appreciation, the constrained nature of the housing system limits access for new households and places increasing pressure on those without ownership.

FIG.16 SINGLE DETACHED HOUSE



FIG.17 CONDOMINIUMS ON BUSTLETON AVENUE

Issues

Tight housing supply

Most of Bustleton's housing stock was built in the three decades following World War II, and that legacy continues to define the neighborhood today. The housing base is largely composed of mid-century single-family homes and garden-style multifamily buildings, with relatively little large-scale redevelopment activity since. This has created a stable but relatively fixed housing inventory, where most growth must come from incremental infill rather than transformational development.

Construction activity slowed considerably after this initial buildout period. While there have been occasional increases in supply, they have not been sustained at a level sufficient to meaningfully expand the housing base. This pattern is evident in more recent trends. Between 2014 and 2020, Bustleton added 820 units, growing from 14,156 to 14,976 units. This represented a modest but meaningful period of expansion. However, that momentum has not continued. From 2020 to 2024, only 98 units were added, marking a sharp deceleration in new housing production.

0%

Homeowner

2.5%

Renter

Aging housing stock

Bustleton's housing stock is defined by its age. More than 73% of units were built during the post–World War II boom, resulting in a relatively uniform housing base. The median age of single-family homes is 62 years, while multifamily buildings are only slightly newer at 61 years. 26% of single-family homes in Bustleton are graded B or better according to OPA data, this compares with 11% for the county. This concentration in age means that a large share of the housing stock is entering similar stages of its lifecycle at the same time.

The implication is not widespread deterioration, but synchronized need. As systems and building components age concurrently, the neighborhood is likely to see increasing demand for reinvestment. Maintenance requirements will become more consistent across properties, while the need for energy efficiency upgrades is growing as older homes fall behind modern performance standards. At the same time, accessibility is becoming a more pressing issue as residents age in place and housing units were not originally designed to accommodate changing mobility needs.

76% built pre-1980



High share of cost-burdened renters

Housing units in Bustleton are primarily owner-occupied, and that trend has strengthened over time. Homeownership has hovered between 60% and 63% in 2024, well above the county's rate of 51.8%. This reinforces Bustleton's position as a stable, middle-income neighborhood with a strong base of long-term residents.

Renters are experiencing a very different reality. A majority, 62%, are cost burdened, spending more than 30% of their income on housing. While the median rent of \$1,315 is slightly below the county median of \$1,397, this does not translate to affordability. Renter incomes are not keeping pace with housing costs, leading to sustained financial pressure.

These dynamics point to a widening gap between owners and renters. Owners are building wealth through appreciation, while renters are increasingly constrained by cost burdens. This is occurring in the

context of a relatively tight housing market, where growth in the number of housing units has remained flat. Limited new supply is reinforcing upward pressure on both home values and rents, making it more difficult for lower-income households to access and remain in the neighborhood.

Opportunities

Demand for new housing

The composition of the housing stock has remained relatively unchanged. The neighborhood continues to skew heavily toward owner-occupied, lower-density housing, with limited introduction of new multifamily buildings. This lack of diversification in housing types further constrains the ability of the market to respond to changing household needs, particularly for renters, smaller households, and first-time buyers.

These supply constraints are directly reflected in current market conditions. Vacancy rates are extremely tight across both tenure types. In 2024, the vacancy rate for owner-occupied units stood at 2.5%, while renter-occupied units reported effectively 0% vacancy in the ACS data. Even accounting for sampling limitations, these figures indicate a market operating at or near full capacity, with virtually no slack to accommodate new demand.



Bustleton Transportation

Bustleton is considerably more car-dependent than the rest of Philadelphia. Bustleton has half the transit ridership and double the car ownership of Philadelphia overall. Wide roads, strip malls, and single-family, detached housing all contribute to the neighborhood's reliance on cars.

Despite these factors, it is clear that access to public transportation is still important. School-aged children often ride the bus, and about six percent of residents commute to work by public transit. New transit investments like the Direct Bus aim to increase access to fast and reliable public transportation. However, reliability, frequency, and accessibility remain major barriers to public transportation usage in the neighborhood.

Issues

Car Dependency

Transportation in Bustleton is defined by high rates of auto ownership and limited access to public transit. According to the 2024 ACS, about three-quarters of residents commute by car, including both alone and by carpool. This is reflective of the high rates of car ownership, which have increased in the past several years. In 2024, only about 14% of households in Bustleton did not own a car, while in 2019, about 18% of households did not own a car.

Limited Transit Access

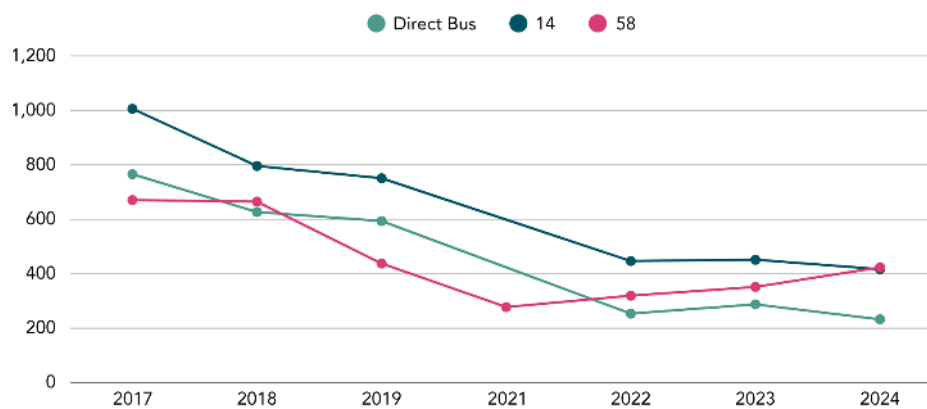
Public transit options are limited to bus routes and the West Trenton regional rail line about one mile northwest of the neighborhood. There are seven bus routes that run regularly through Bustleton. Of those seven lines, three of them run less than twice an hour: routes 88, 19, and 1. The other four bus lines (67, 58, 14, Direct Bus) have a frequency of half hour or less. However, actual headways often differ from predicted headways, resulting in delays and bunching. In addition to the seven bus routes mentioned, there are about an additional dozen lines that run through the neighborhood and operate only at peak hours when school is in session (400, 450, 452, 461, 475, 476, 477, 478, 484, 492, 495).

Bus ridership has fluctuated since before the pandemic. Although the Direct Bus route has purportedly seen increases in overall ridership since its introduction in 2017, the route's stops in Bustleton saw declining usage even before the pandemic. Other frequent bus routes, like the 14 and the 58, saw similar trends in ridership. As of 2024, it seems bus ridership in Bustleton has failed to return to pre-pandemic levels, even as ridership was declining previously. This may be correlated with the increase in car ownership, as well as an increase in the share of residents working from home.

Lack of Bus Shelter

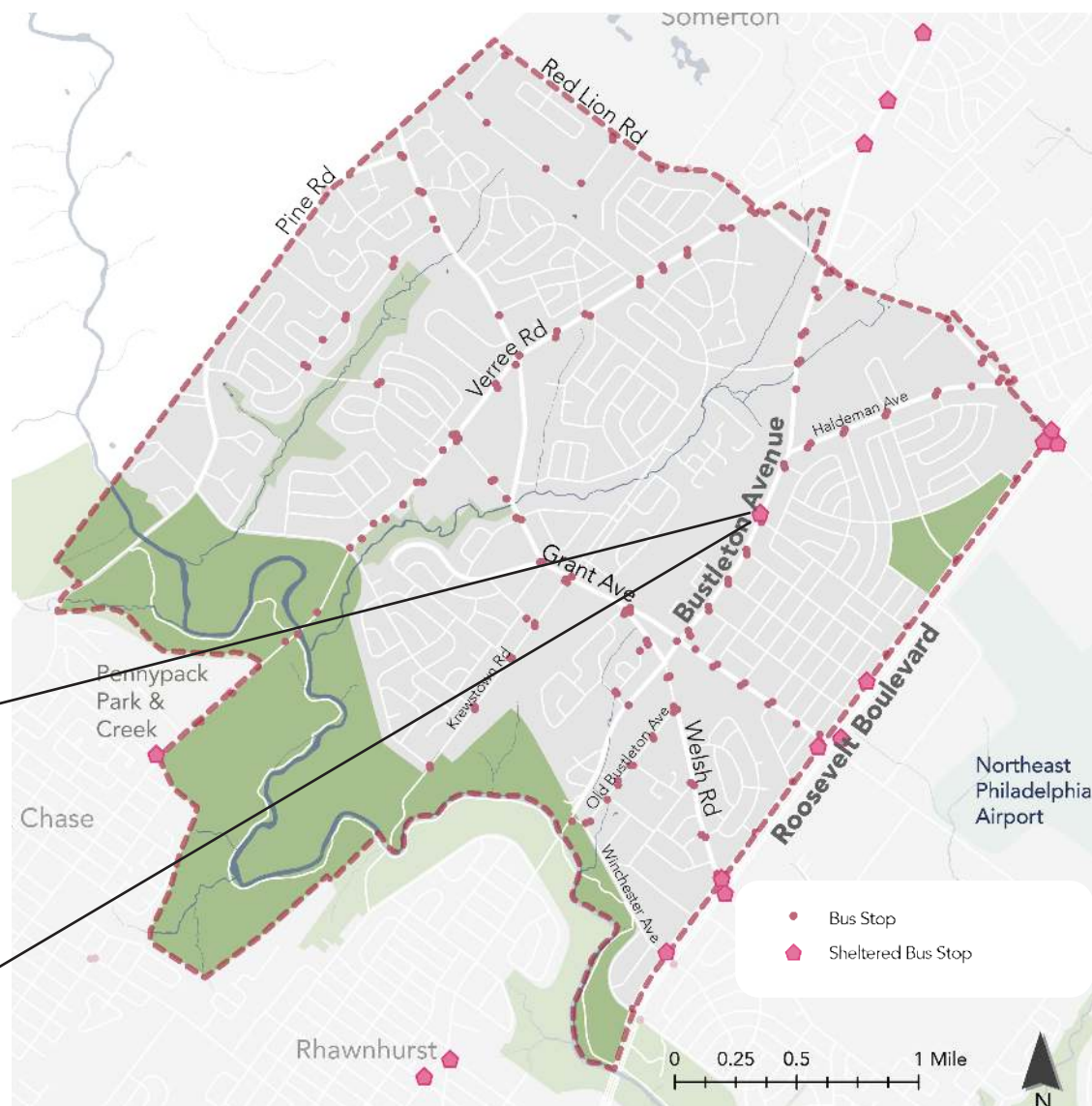
The majority of bus shelters in the neighborhood are distributed along Roosevelt Boulevard. Some

FIG.18 WEEKDAY BUS RIDERSHIP ESTIMATES



of these bus shelters were built for routes 1 and 14, while all of the new bus shelters were built for the Direct Bus. These newer bus shelters tend to be more elaborate than the older shelters, with larger signage and more seating. Only one official bus shelter exists on Bustleton Avenue: at the intersection of the avenue and Bowler Street, heading south (this shelter is pictured in the center of the photo collage). An unofficial bus shelter seems to have been built in front of the Paul's Run Retirement Community on Bustleton Avenue (also pictured right), reflecting the need for more comfortable bus facilities.

The majority of bus stops lack both seating and protection from extreme weather conditions. Considering that residents may have to wait over half an hour for their bus to arrive, the lack of shelter can become a public health concern during heat waves in the summer months. This is especially problematic for vulnerable populations like the elderly, as it would be difficult for them to comfortably wait for a bus for most of stops in the neighborhood.



Opportunities

Public Transit Access to Commercial

Currently, Bustleton's commercial corridors are well served by buses. Bus routes 19, 67, 58, 14, 1, and the Direct Bus all stop either near or directly in front of multiple shopping centers. Two of those bus routes (Direct Bus and 58) are part of SEPTA's Frequent Bus Network. This connection is especially important for the 58 bus route and Bustleton Avenue, where there is the greatest concentration of commercial activity serving residents. The spacing of the stops allows easy access for bus riders to any of the shopping centers, as every commercial strip has at least one bus stop directly in its vicinity.

Regional Transit Connections

Bustleton is equidistant from various regional destinations. The Direct Bus was introduced in 2017 as part of the Route for Change Program, and provides service from Frankford Transportation Center to Neshaminy Mall at headways of 10-15 minutes. Travel time is about 15 minutes for a rider boarding at the Grant Avenue stop to reach Neshaminy Mall, and about 15 minutes to reach the Frankford Transportation Center.

The West Trenton regional rail line allows residents to "park and ride." The station is about a 10 minute drive or less for Bustleton residents, depending on where they live in the neighborhood. The station is

also accessible with bus route 88. From the Bethayres station, it takes about 40 minutes to reach the Suburban Station in Center City and about 40 minutes to reach West Trenton. For residents commuting into Center City during peak hours, the regional rail line is slightly more convenient than driving, as the estimated travel time by driving is between 50 minutes and an hour in total.



FIG.19 SHELTERED DIRECT BUS STOP



FIG.20 REGIONAL RAIL STATION CREDIT: PHILADELPHIA INQUIRER





Bustleton Micro-Mobility

Bustleton Avenue is a primary commercial and residential corridor in Northeast Philadelphia. While it serves thousands of residents daily, its current design strongly favors automobile travel at the expense of pedestrians, cyclists, and transit users.

This section examines the current state of micro-mobility along and around the Bustleton Avenue corridor, identifies key issues, and outlines opportunities for improvement to guide future interventions.

Bustleton Avenue functions as a wide, high-speed arterial road cutting through a dense residential neighborhood. Originally widened to four lanes in the 1970s, the street design prioritizes throughput for automobiles over the safety and comfort of the many residents who must or might want to navigate it on foot, by bike, or by transit. The result is a corridor that is physically inhospitable for micro-mobility: missing and damaged sidewalks, a high-stress painted bike lane, minimal shade and weather protection, and no meaningful connections to nearby green spaces like Pennypack Park.

The corridor sits within a primarily residential community with large populations of children, and seniors—groups that would benefit from infrastructure for walking, cycling, and transit. Many of these residents must navigate the avenue daily to reach schools, healthcare, grocery stores, and employment.

Snapshot of Existing Infrastructure:

Sidewalks: Partial coverage; missing on one or both sides along several blocks

Bike Facilities: Unprotected bike lane on Bustleton Ave

Bike Parking: Absent from commercial sections of the corridor

Pedestrian Crossings: Wide intersections with long crossing distances

Tree Canopy: Limited along the avenue, exposing pedestrians to heat and noise



FIG.21 POOR SIDEWALK COVERAGE ON WINCHESTER AVE

FIG.1 CAR ENCROACHING THE BIKE LANE ON BUSTLETON AVENUE

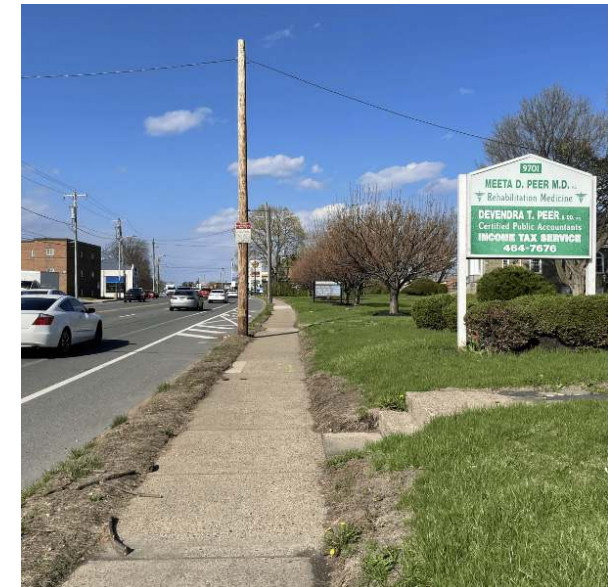


FIG.22 SPARSE TREE CANOPY ON BUSTLETON AVENUE

Issues

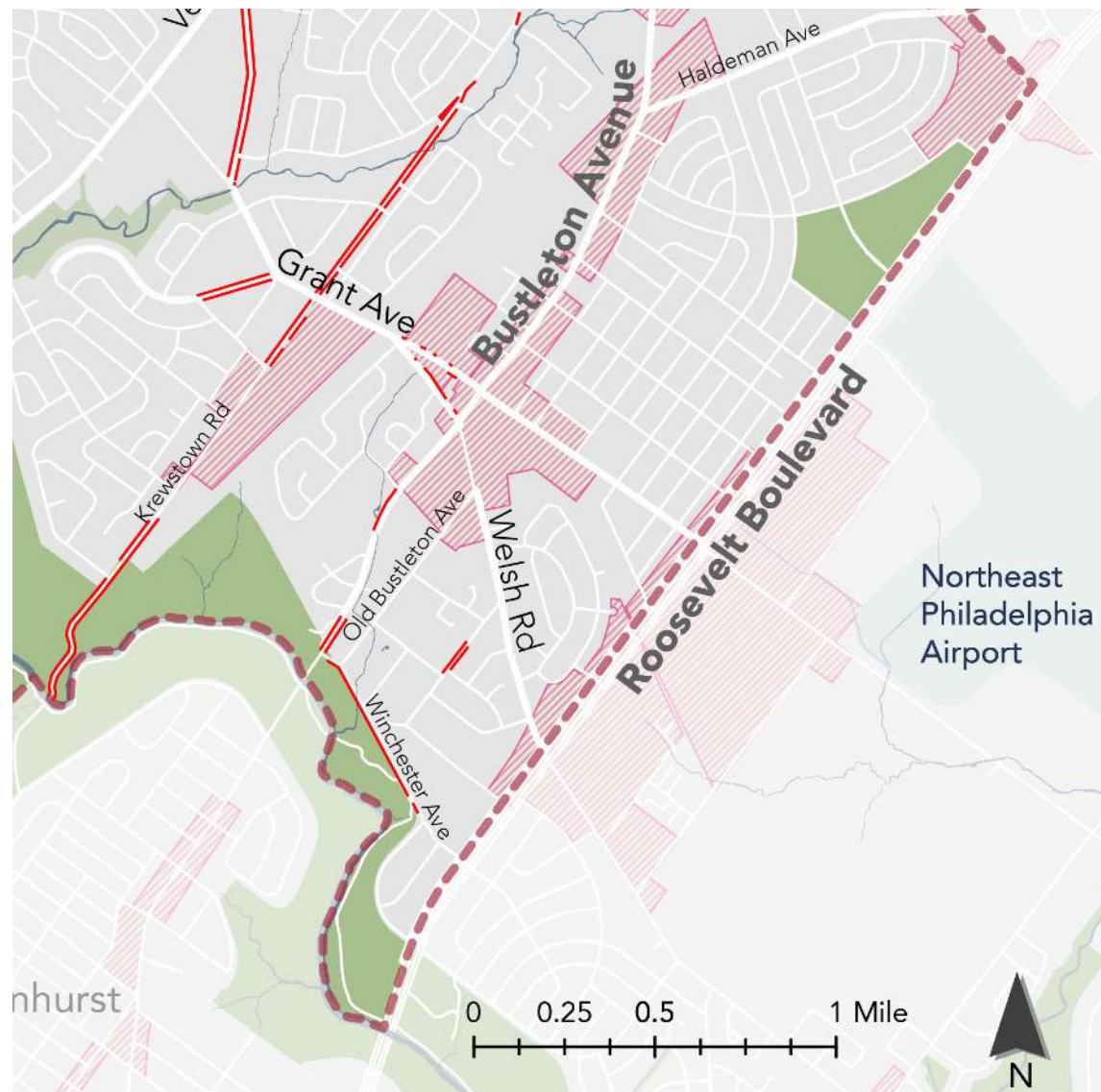
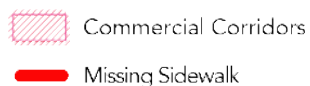
Access Gaps: Incomplete Sidewalks

Many streets in the Bustleton corridor lack sidewalks on one or both sides, including segments of Bustleton Avenue. Residents and visitors must frequently step into the roadway or cross the street multiple times to maintain continuous pedestrian movement.

This fragmentation has a measurable dampening effect on walkability. When a pedestrian cannot rely on a safe, continuous path to their destination, the friction of navigating the corridor makes driving, or not traveling at all, the more attractive choice.

Safety: High Injury Network

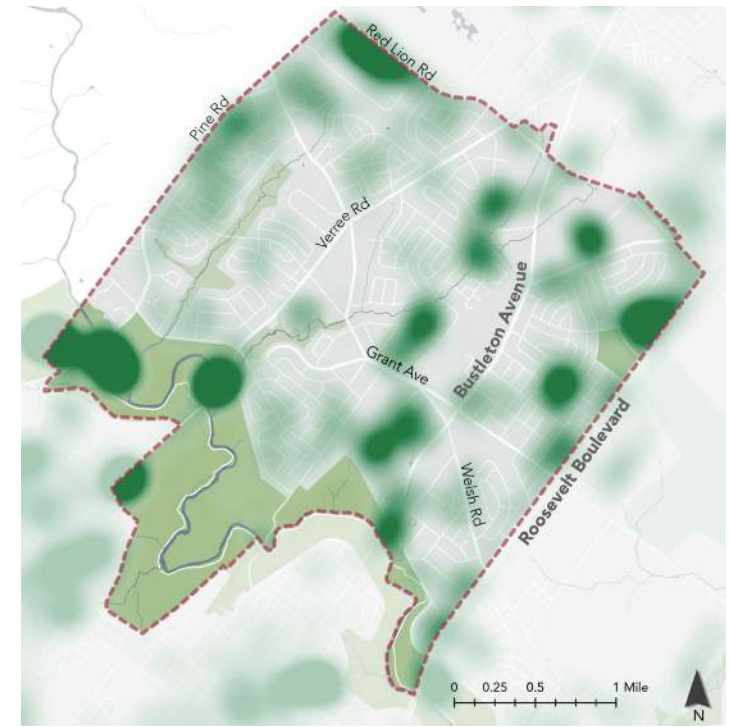
This designation reflects a pattern of chronic danger for all non-auto users on the corridor. The road's width encourages speeding: vehicles routinely exceed the posted speed limit on this four-lane arterial. Unlike Roosevelt Boulevard, where newly installed speed cameras have demonstrated measurable reductions in vehicle speeds, Bustleton Avenue remains without automated speed enforcement, leaving pedestrians and cyclists unprotected.



Thermal Comfort: Lack of Tree Canopy

The physical comfort of the walking environment is a key determinant of whether people choose to walk. Bustleton Avenue's limited tree cover leaves pedestrians exposed to intense summer heat, wind, and the noise and exhaust of adjacent traffic.

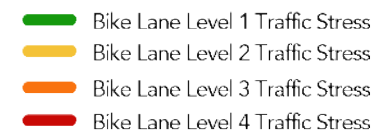
Research consistently links tree canopy to increased walking and cycling activity. In the absence of shade and weather protection, even residents who are willing to walk are deterred during extreme weather: a growing concern as climate conditions intensify. The lack of street trees also has broader impacts on air quality, stormwater management, and mental health along the corridor.



Lack of Biking Infrastructure

Although Bustleton Avenue includes a designated bike lane, it is painted white and unprotected. It is adjacent to two lanes of moving vehicle traffic. The Delaware Valley Regional Planning Commission (DVRPC) has rated this facility at the second-highest level of traffic stress (LTS) on its scale—meaning it is suitable only for experienced, confident cyclists and is effectively inaccessible to the majority of residents; including children, seniors, and casual riders.

Compounding this, the commercial sections of Bustleton Avenue offer no bicycle parking. Cyclists who do manage to navigate the avenue have nowhere to safely secure their bikes at their destination, creating a final-mile deterrent that undermines any investment in cycling access.



Opportunities

Road Diet: Reclaiming Space

Bustleton Avenue was widened to four lanes in the 1970s. Its current width—the very characteristic that makes it so inhospitable to non-auto users, paradoxically creates a significant opportunity: there is physical space to redesign.

A road diet would reduce Bustleton from four vehicle lanes to two or three, reallocating the reclaimed space to protected bike lanes, wider sidewalks, street trees, and dedicated transit infrastructure. Road diets consistently reduce vehicle speeds, decrease crash rates, and improve the experience for all users without meaningfully increasing travel times for drivers on corridors where traffic volumes allow.

Behavioral changes do not happen overnight, but within here lies a roadmap to change patterns through sustained effort. A road diet would encourage residents to be thoughtful of their speeds. The “Drive CarePhilly Signs,” around the neighborhood would find meaningful realization within drivers on the avenue. This would not only ensure a safer neighborhood, but a more vibrant space for its inhabitants. This is a significant measure as it would aid the senior population along with many young children as there are various day care centers for both adults and children, and the commercial center is walking distance from the corridor. Yet, because of poor infrastructure it seems impossible.

Pennypack Park Access Paths

Bustleton Avenue intersects with Pennypack Park—a large urban park in the city of Philadelphia. However, the current intersection is entirely car-oriented, with no meaningful pedestrian or bicycle connection to the park.

This is a significant missed opportunity. A redesigned access point at the Bustleton–Pennypack intersection could transform this node into a celebrated entry point for the park, with protected crossings, wayfinding signage, bike facilities, and landscaping that announces the transition from an urban corridor to a natural amenity. This would benefit both local residents and the broader region.

The significant lack of sidewalk infrastructure decreases accessibility for the residents, multiple broken sidewalks or missing ones create an opportunity to improve access to the park promoting healthy habits and linking them to a major asset not only within the neighborhood but the city of Philadelphia. The lack of existing infrastructure presents an opportunity to be imaginative with what could be integrated within makeup of the neighborhood infrastructure. This means that it not only improves walkability but promotes community connection in a neighborhood that is inter-generational and multi-cultural.

Depicted above is a desired access path from the Penny Pack Park to Bustleton Avenue, changing the characteristic busy thoroughfare to an accessible node for the neighborhood, making sure residents of the neighborhood feel connected to the park.

FIG.23 STREET-SECTION OF BUSTLETON AVENUE (APPLE MAPS)



FIG.24 BUSTLETON AVENUE OVERPASS INTERSECTING PENNYPACK PARK



Bustleton Placemaking

Many of the micro-mobility concerns connect to our observation of the lack of activity and public life in spaces in Bustleton. Having active public spaces is about more than having many bodies in a public space, but rather about fostering a sense of identity and connection between people and place; it is “a form of social capital that shapes the residents’ personal identities, fosters a degree of community member rootedness in a place, provides us with a measure of livability for that place, and creates a sense of well-being...” (Ellery, 2019, pg. 238). While Bustleton has significant barriers to a cohesive sense of place, there are many unique features within the neighborhood to build upon, such as grassroots demonstrated desire for renovation and improvements in plazas, underutilized surface parking space, and the impressive diversity of multicultural and multigenerational residents and businesses. This section will first walk through existing issues, then expand on these opportunities as they relate to the goals of reclaiming Bustleton Ave’s identity as the ‘Main Street’ of the community and fostering cross-cultural and inter-generational interaction in the community.

Issues

Lack of Integration of Pennypack Park with Bustleton Ave.

Pennypack Park is one of the biggest green spaces in Philadelphia, and one of the defining characteristics of Bustleton. Residents we spoke with mentioned their love for recreation within the park, whether for walking, running, biking, bird-watching, and connecting to

nature. However, there is no park access point on Bustleton Ave, or on Old Bustleton Ave. Rather, the intersection is a wide, car bridge, and the design prioritizes the efficiency of moving cars across the park at the expense of signaling the park as a place to go, to slow down, to stop, to linger, or to gather.

Pennypack Park as a destination and activity is only feasibly connected to other destinations and activities within Bustleton by car. The current design of the intersection within our defined limits of Bustleton has no indication that the park is underneath the roadway or where the nearest trail access point is, with street signage. We determined the closest access point to be on Winchester Ave, approximately a 10-minute walk away from the bus stop for line 58. Figure XXXX shows the place where off-trail walking would get you to the trail the quickest from the closest Route 58 bus stop. Figure XXXX shows the view from within the off-trail wilderness just on the other side of the barrier, and Figure XXXX shows the view of Avenue from the perspective of the designated trail. Figure XXXX shows the south side of Winchester Ave, the side of the street with the trail access point, but which lacks a sidewalk, and as we observed on our site visit, turning cars present an uncomfortable proximity between pedestrians forced to walk on the road and cars.

Thus, while Pennypack Park is a beloved public amenity, access to the park is abutted by private properties, and there aren’t clear invitations for people not ‘in the know’ to navigate entering and enjoying the park. This limits the degree to which the park feels like part of the ‘place’ that is Bustleton.



Auto-oriented commercial access

Not only does green space not feel like it's well integrated in space, but commercial areas also lack a sense of place and public life. Linger in commercial areas is not just good for business; it also exposes people to more social interactions. One issue limiting the potential for commercial areas to serve as sites of public life is the auto-oriented access to storefronts.

Concretely, this can be a barrier to public gathering or lingering in different ways; Figure XXXX shows a relatively small shopping center with a packed parking lot, and the density of cars, along with the need to leave space for moving cars through the center, leaves no extra space, and an uncomfortable proximity to car traffic even walking the short distance from the sidewalk or a parked car to a store. Similarly, because auto-oriented access is the biggest design priority, the parking spaces come as close as possible to the storefront, leaving little room for people to gather in between the parking and the storefront, and a somewhat uncomfortable proximity to vehicles when rare gatherings do occur. These factors contribute to commercial areas feeling transactional and liminal, rather than being an area people are likely to find inherently interesting and attracted to linger in.

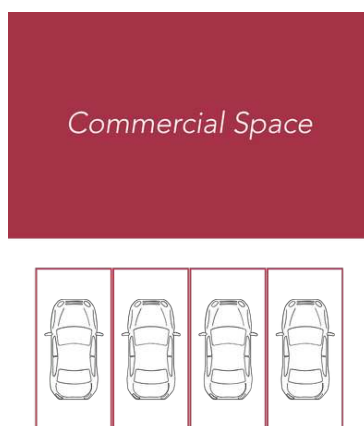
Car-oriented commercial zoning

Outside of freely made auto-oriented design choices in strip malls, car-oriented zoning imposes regulatory limitations on the built form that inhibit the kinds of change that would encourage placemaking.

The Philadelphia CA zoning code requires up to 4

parking spaces per 1000 sq ft of commercial space, which results in a very skewed ratio of space reserved for potential cars to the space humans occupy. Figure XXXX shows that the ratio of commercial to parking space, given standard parking spot sizes, is roughly equal. Figures XXXX and XXXX show what the ratio looks like in an example CA1-zoned plaza in Bustleton. The first shows the street-view, pedestrian sidewalk perspective; the storefronts are barely visible and most of the field of view is taken up by cars or empty asphalt cover without seating, decoration, or greenery. Figure XXXX shows that the space reserved for parking in the Presidential Plaza is likely even greater than the commercial space; the CA zoning code sets parking minimums but there are no maximums.

CA zoning also restricts residential use, helping create conditions that mean people are living farther away from commercial areas and more likely to use a car to get there, contributing further to the liminality and transactional nature of these spaces.



Aging commercial buildings

Aging plaza infrastructure poses a significant barrier to placemaking and the cultivation of meaningful social connections in public space. Minimally decorated, deteriorating buildings signify a lack of collective care for the environment, sending an implicit message that the space is neither valued nor intended for sustained public engagement. During interviews with community members, residents expressed concern that the structures were past their prime and “due for a facelift”. These sentiments reflect a deeper disinvestment from the civic fabric of the plaza. When facades are worn, signage is faded, and architectural features go unmaintained, the space fails to communicate the warmth, vibrancy, and symbolic

importance that draw people together. Placemaking depends on environments that invite lingering, spark curiosity, and foster a sense of shared ownership; aging infrastructure does the opposite, signaling neglect and discouraging the kind of informal encounters and repeat visits that underpin strong community bonds.

Opportunities

Underutilized surface parking space.

As mentioned above, some plaza parking lots are very full, but others remain largely empty, such as the Presidential Plaza mentioned before (Figure XXXX), and other examples, such as the lot at Welsh and

Bustleton (Figure XXXX). Surface Parking is fairly empty a lot of the time, creating vast expanses of asphalt that prioritize vehicle storage over human-centered activity. These underutilized areas represent significant untapped potential for incremental placemaking interventions that could transform sterile commercial environments into welcoming community spaces.

While these lots are privately owned, privately owned public spaces (POPS) can still serve vital community functions when thoughtfully activated, and such spaces are better than no public space at all. The current design of these parking areas constitute dead space which fail to invite human activity despite their physical accessibility. However, their existing infrastructure, flat surfaces, and central locations within



FIG.25 AGING COMMERCIAL BUILDINGS AT PRESIDENTIAL PLAZA



FIG.26 EMPTY SURFACE PARKING LOT AT PRESIDENTIAL PLAZA

commercial districts make them ideal candidates for lighter, quicker, and cheaper interventions that can demonstrate placemaking potential without major capital investment. Incorporating elements such as seating areas, shade structures, community bulletin boards, designated spaces for informal markets, and maybe long-term residential units, that encourage lingering and social connection, could shift the character of a site from utilitarian to welcoming and activated.

The flexibility inherent in surface parking also creates opportunities for adaptive programming that can respond to community needs and cultural rhythms. Weekend farmers markets, evening cultural performances, or seasonal festivals could activate these spaces during off-peak parking hours, demonstrating their potential as multi-use community assets. This approach recognizes that successful placemaking often requires working within existing property constraints while gradually expanding community expectations about what commercial spaces can provide.

Local businesses are adding gathering spaces.

There are many examples within the Bustleton strip malls of business owners using outdoor furniture to create opportunity for assembly and gathering within plazas. For example, figures XXXX and XXXX show two restaurants in different plazas within Bustleton that have implemented outdoor dining seating. This shows that business owners are already bought in to the fact that public gathering spots benefit their businesses,

and this could be built upon and further coordinated amongst all businesses within a given plaza.

Unique cultural identities and intergenerational nature of the population

There are large concentrations of different immigrant ethnic groups and multiple generations with different art forms, culinary traditions, religious practices, and languages that are assets for community placemaking. Rather than viewing cultural diversity as a challenge to overcome, this heterogeneity can be the foundation for different ways of being in public, coexisting, and cross-pollinating.

The intergenerational nature of these communities adds another layer of placemaking potential. Elderly residents often serve as repositories of cultural knowledge, storytelling traditions, and informal social networks, while younger generations may bring more technological fluency, artistic innovation, and connections to broader metropolitan networks. Intergenerational interactions represent a social capital that can be leveraged in placemaking initiatives.



FIG.27 LOCAL BUSINESS DEPICTING THE MULTI-CULTURAL PRESENCE IN BUSTLETON

FIG.28 CHICKPEAS STOREFRONT WITH OUTDOOR SEATING



FIG.29 COMMUNITY EVENT WITH NEW WORLD ASSOCIATION, CREDIT: NWA



Issues

Bustleton is characterized by mid twentieth century suburban development. The commercial layout primarily consist of one story strip mall arranged in linear formations, with large surface parking lots separating storefronts from the roadway. The strip mall clusters have contributed to local employment, community services, and sustain a diverse range of local businesses. However, improved regional accessibility has increased competition from commercial destinations outside the neighborhood. Despite their proximity to residential areas, auto dependent site layouts limit pedestrian access and reduce interaction between adjacent businesses. The lack of continuous pedestrian infrastructure further weakens the connections.

Aging Commercial Properties

Commercial properties in Bustleton are largely mid twentieth century developments, with an average building age of approximately 55 years. Many buildings were constructed between 51 and 75 years ago in a post-war development period associated with suburban strip mall design. These mid-century properties commonly consist of linear strip malls and standalone commercial buildings with underutilized space. The prevalence of this similar strip commercial layout limits the presence of shared public space and reinforces parking-oriented designs. This pattern contributes to fragmented commercial environments and reduces opportunities for cohesive pedestrian business activity.

Auto-oriented Commercial Corridors

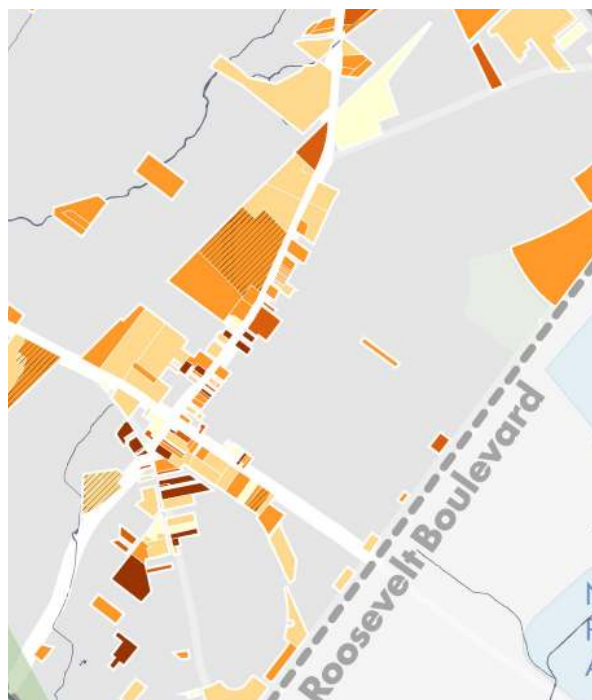
Commercial corridors in Bustleton are primarily designed for automobile access. According to the 2017 Far Northeast District Plan's community engagement results, 100% of respondents currently travel to shopping destinations by car. However, preferences differ from existing conditions, with 50% of respondents indicating a desire to walk to shopping areas, compared to 33% who prefer driving and 17% who prefer shuttle or other modes. This gap between current travel behavior and preferred access mode reflects limited pedestrian connectivity in existing commercial areas. Storefront parking, dispersed strip mall layouts, and commercial development along arterial roads such as Bustleton Avenue and Grant Avenue contribute to environments that prioritize vehicular access over walkability. These conditions reduce opportunities for continuous pedestrian movement and limit interaction between adjacent businesses.

- Suburban Strip Mall
- Commercial Parking
- Corridor Business
- Sidewalk without Trees

FIG.30 PRESIDENTIAL PLAZA



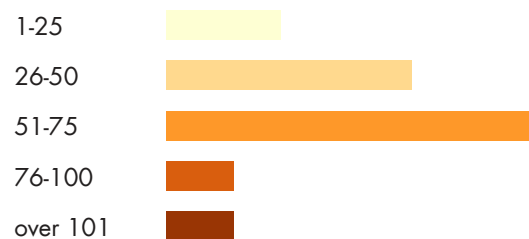
FIG.31 MAP OF COMMERCIAL PROPERTIES BY AGE



Property Age

Median Age **55**

Industry 



Opportunity

Diverse Community Retail Base

Bustleton contains established retail strips that support a wide range of local businesses, including daily retail, food service, community services, and auto-related businesses. These activities are distributed across existing commercial corridors and reflect a diverse local economic base. Retail and service sectors together account for approximately 27% of jobs in Bustleton, indicating their continued importance in the neighborhood economy. This diversity demonstrates strong potential for expanded business mix and service upgrading. The presence of clustered commercial strips also provides a practical foundation for reinvestment and for improving pedestrian infrastructure that strengthens connections between businesses and surrounding residential areas.

Healthcare Industry

The health care sector represents the largest employment provider in Bustleton, accounting for 44% of local jobs and showing approximately 12% growth over the past decade. Health-related businesses are distributed throughout the neighborhood, contributing to local employment and service provision. Life expectancy indicators show higher values in Bustleton compared to Philadelphia overall, with women averaging 80.7 years and men 78.5 years, compared to 79.3 and 72.3 years citywide. These conditions reflect the presence of health-related services as a significant component of the local economy.

Concrete actions that respond to the existing conditions, and challenges, charting a path toward improvement across identified dimensions of neighborhood life.



Strategies & Recommendations

Using the issues and opportunities as our foundation, 9 strategies and 33 individual recommendations have been identified to advance the vision and goals for the neighborhood. Each strategy outlines a general approach for addressing one or more issues, and each recommendation directly supports one or more goals that have been envisioned. The phased implementation of these recommendations is summarized by the Timeline Matrix on the following page.

Strategy 1: Implement Streetscape Improvements

Strategy 2: Install Traffic Calming Measures

Strategy 3: Improve Public Transportation

Strategy 4: Rezone Within Our Study Area

Strategy 5: Support Residential Stability

Strategy 6: Reinvest in Commercial Spaces

Strategy 7: Promote Culture & Local Business

Strategy 8: Improve Access to Pennypack Park

Strategy 9: Create a Community Development Corporation for Bustleton

Implementation Matrix

Topic	Recommendation	Year	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	Goals	Cost
Placemaking	Activate vacant land												 	\$
	Parking lot pop-up events												 	\$
	Expand mural network												 	\$-\$
	Cultural landmark signage												 	\$-\$
	Wayfinding signage												 	\$-\$
	Multilingual road signage												 	\$-\$
	Neighborhood park cleanups												 	\$
	Gateway for Pennypack Park												 	\$-\$
Local economy	Establish a CDC												 	\$
	Facade improvements												 	\$-\$
	Activate vacant storefronts												 	\$
	Multicultural food tours												 	\$
	Farmers market												 	\$
Housing	Convert auto-oriented zoning												 	-
	Upzone Bustleton Avenue												 	-
	Allow infill development												 	-
	Affordable housing overlay												 	-
	Existing housing programs												 	\$
	Aging-in-place programs												 	\$
	Home energy efficiency												 	\$
													 	\$
Transportation	Install bus shelters												 	\$-\$-\$-\$
	Install digital bus signage												 	\$-\$-\$-\$
	Improve bus frequency												 	\$-\$
Micro-mobility	Create a road diet												 	\$-\$
	Widen sidewalks												 	\$-\$-\$-\$
	Protected bike lanes												 	\$-\$-\$-\$
	Extend sidewalk coverage												 	\$-\$
	Plant street trees												 	\$-\$-\$-\$
	High-visibility crosswalks												 	\$-\$
	Curb extensions												 	\$-\$
	Bike parking												 	\$
	Speed limit enforcement												 	\$-\$-\$-\$
	Bridge redesign												 	\$-\$
													 	\$
													 	\$-\$-\$-\$

Lighter colors signify planning & pilot phases
Darker colors signify implementation

Enhancing the streetscape along Bustleton Avenue is critical to creating a more walkable, attractive, and cohesive commercial corridor. With approximately 25,000 vehicles traveling the corridor daily, high traffic volumes contribute to speeding, unsafe crossings, and a less inviting environment for shoppers and residents. Implementing traffic calming measures is essential to improving safety, reducing crash risk, and supporting the corridor's economic vitality. Currently, inconsistent sidewalks, limited greenery, and a lack of clear wayfinding contribute to a fragmented pedestrian experience. Strategic improvements can significantly enhance the public realm, making the corridor more inviting for residents, visitors, and businesses alike.

Bustleton Avenue could be more than just a commercial strip. Its diverse shopping centers serve residents of all backgrounds; its daycare centers and schools make it a daily route for children and families; and its senior care facilities mean that older adults—a quarter of Bustleton's population—depend on the corridor for essential services. These users deserve a street environment that is safe, comfortable, and accessible regardless of whether they arrive by car, bus, or on foot. Key interventions include installing wayfinding signage to highlight destinations and improve navigation, adding street trees along Bustleton and Grant Avenues to provide shade, improve air quality, and visually soften the corridor, and upgrading and widening sidewalks to ensure accessibility and comfort for all users. Collectively, these improvements would strengthen the identity of Bustleton Avenue as a vibrant neighborhood center. A true Main Street for the Far Northeast.

Recommendation 1.1: Install Wayfinding Signage

Recommendation 1.2: Plant Street Trees

Recommendation 1.3: Install High-Visibility Crosswalks

Recommendation 1.4: Improve Sidewalk Coverage

Recommendation 1.5: Widen Sidewalks in front of commercial strips

Recommendation 1.6: Install Bike Storage

Recommendation 1.1

Install Wayfinding Signage

Bustleton Avenue functions as the neighborhood's primary commercial corridor, yet it lacks the signage infrastructure needed to help residents and visitors navigate between its destinations. Without clear wayfinding, the corridor reads as a sequence of disconnected strip mall parking lots. Installing a coordinated system of wayfinding signage would give Bustleton Avenue a legible identity, directing pedestrians to key destinations such as local businesses, Pennypack Park, transit stops, community institutions, and civic spaces. A well-designed signage system does more than orient it signals investment and civic care, encouraging people to slow down, explore on foot, and linger longer in the corridor.

The City of Philadelphia's Streets Department manages sign installation and maintenance through its existing traffic sign program, while the Commerce Department has supported corridor branding initiatives in other Philadelphia neighborhood commercial districts. Engage community members, including non-English-speaking residents, to identify priority destinations and preferred language representation on signage. The plan recommends that the implementing wing lead with public engagement and involve existing stakeholders like the GBCL, NWA, and the CDC that will ideally be in place by the time the second round of wayfinding signage is installed, to identify priority destinations and preferred routes before finalizing sign placement.

PRIORITY
Medium

COST
\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short

ENTITIES
Streets Dept

+ Commerce dept
+ Philadelphia City
Planning Commission
(PCPC)



FIG. 32 WAYFINDING
SIGNAGE FROM
MANHATTAN, NYC



FIG. 33 "THE LOOP," IN ST.
LOUIS MISSOURI



FIG. 34 WALK!PHILADELPHIA
SIGN , CCD

PRIORITY High

COST
\$\$ - \$\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Medium

ENTITIES Philadelphia Parks & Recreation

+ Streets dept
+ Office of
Transportation and
Infrastructure Systems
(OTIS)

Recommendation 1.2 Plant Street Trees

Bustleton Avenue's commercial corridor lacks tree cover. The absence of street trees contributes to a hot, exposed pedestrian environment that discourages walking and detracts from the corridor's visual appeal. Planting street trees along Bustleton and Grant Avenues would provide shade for pedestrians, reduce the urban heat island effect, and dramatically improve the aesthetic quality of the streetscape.

Philadelphia's Philly Tree Plan, adopted in 2023, establishes a citywide goal of expanding tree canopy and prioritizes street tree planting in neighborhoods with low canopy cover, a category that includes a part of the Bustleton Avenue corridor as medium priority and also classifies it as medium health risk exposure. While this represents a significant investment, it can be phased over multiple planting seasons—some species planted in spring, others in fall—making it manageable within existing city programs.

Philadelphia Parks & Recreation and the Streets Department jointly oversee street tree planting, and the Philly Tree Plan provides a direct funding and implementation pathway for this recommendation.

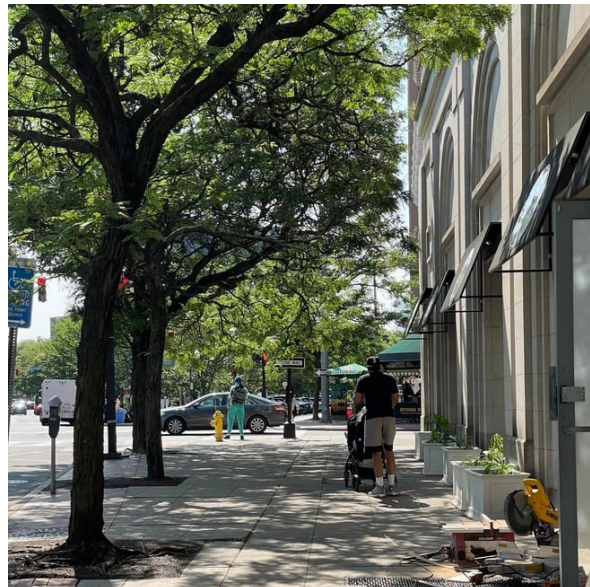


FIG.35 STREET TREES FROM
DOWNTOWN STAMFORD, CT.

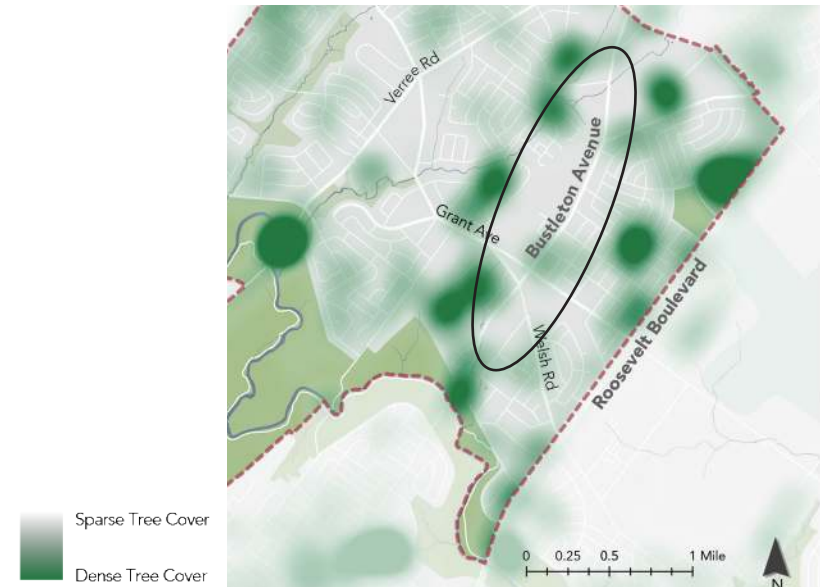


FIG.36 TREE DENSITY NEAR
BUSTLETON AVENUE

Recommendation 1.3

Install High-Visibility Crosswalks

Pedestrian safety at Bustleton Avenue's key intersections is a persistent concern. The corridor's wide travel lanes and high vehicle speeds create crossing environments that are intimidating and dangerous, particularly for older adults and children, two vulnerable groups that make up a substantial share of Bustleton's population. High-visibility crosswalks at priority intersections would improve pedestrian safety by increasing driver awareness, reducing vehicle speeds at crossings, and providing clear, legible pathways for people on foot. Potential intersections could be Bustleton Avenue:

1. Bowler Street
2. President Street
3. Grant Ave
4. Welsh Road
5. Red Lion Road

CASE STUDY

Tactical Urbanism

Location: Baltimore, MD

Entity: City of Baltimore Department of Transportation, in partnership with local community organizations



FIG.37 SCHOOL SLOW ZONE IN SEOUL

Description: Baltimore deployed high-visibility crosswalks with bold, colorful designs at key intersections along neighborhood commercial streets. The installations were paired with community engagement, allowing residents to participate in the design process and select patterns that reflected local identity.

Lesson for Bustleton: High-visibility crosswalks at Bustleton Avenue's busiest intersections would deliver immediate safety benefits at relatively low cost. Incorporating community-designed or culturally reflective patterns into the crosswalk design—drawing on Bustleton's Eastern European, South Asian, and Central Asian heritage—would transform a standard safety intervention into a statement of neighborhood identity. The Vision Zero PHL Slow Zone Program provides an existing city framework through which this recommendation can be implemented.

PRIORITY
High

COST
\$ - \$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short

ENTITIES
Streets dept
+ OTIS

PRIORITY High

COST
\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short

ENTITIES
Streets dept
+ PennDOT

Recommendation 1.4 Improve Sidewalks Coverage on Bustleton Avenue

Bustleton Avenue currently discourages pedestrians as sidewalk coverage is not contiguous. This is both a safety hazard and a fundamental barrier to the kind of walkable corridor experience the plan envisions. Filling in existing sidewalk gaps along Bustleton Avenue is among the most foundational investments this plan recommends. This particularly could serve children, and seniors who would benefit from easy access by foot to the various facilities located in the corridor.

The plan recommends that the Streets Department prioritize this gap as part of its capital improvement planning, coordinating with property owners where applicable. This intervention should be coordinated with street tree planting (Recommendation 1.2) and sidewalk widening (Recommendation 1.5) to ensure a consistent, high-quality pedestrian environment is achieved in a single coordinated effort.



FIG.38 SIDEWALK NEAR PENNYPACK PARK ENDS ABRUPTLY

- Religious Organizations
- Schools
- Senior Housing
- + Health Clinic
- H Hospital
- Missing Sidewalk

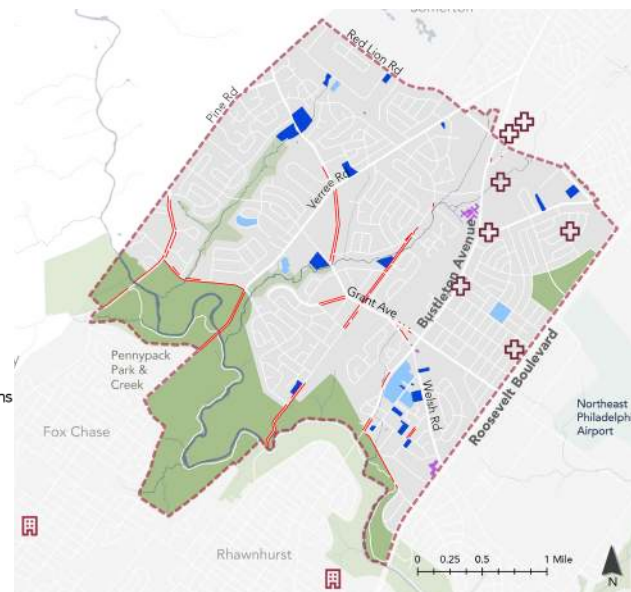


FIG.39 MISSING SIDEWALK INFRASTRUCTURE AND NEARBY COMMUNITY ASSETS

Recommendation 1.5

Widen Sidewalks in Front of Commercial Strips

Even where sidewalks exist along Bustleton Avenue, many are too narrow to comfortably accommodate the mix of pedestrian activity—shoppers, stroller-pushers, older adults with mobility aids—that a thriving commercial corridor could generate. Widening sidewalks in front of Bustleton Avenue’s commercial strips would create space for spontaneous social interactions that make a Main Street feel alive.

Current sidewalk widths in front of many commercial properties along the corridor fall below the minimum recommended for an active commercial streetscape. Widening to a minimum of 12 feet in commercial areas—consistent with PennDOT’s active transportation guidelines—would allow for a clear pedestrian through-zone, a furniture and landscaping zone adjacent to the curb, and a frontage zone in front of businesses.

This recommendation is closely linked to street tree planting (Recommendation 1.2) and sidewalk gap filling (Recommendation 1.4) and should be planned in coordination with those efforts. PennDOT’s Active Transportation program and the DVRPC’s Walk program both offer technical assistance and potential funding pathways for sidewalk widening on state-classified roads.



FIG.40 STREETVIEW OF NARROW SIDEWALKS ON BUSTLETON AVENUE (APPLE MAPS)



FIG.41 A PICTORAL REPRESENTATION OF THE CURRENT SIDEWALK INFRASTRUCTURE NEAR COMMERCIAL STRIPS

PRIORITY
Medium

COST
\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short

ENTITIES
Streets dept

+ PennDOT
+ OTIS

PRIORITY

MediumCOST
\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE

Short

ENTITIES

Streets dept

+ PennDOT

+ OTIS

Recommendation 1.6

Install Bike Storage

Bustleton Avenue's commercial corridor currently offers almost no secure bike parking. This is a missed opportunity: even in a car-dependent neighborhood, the absence of bike racks signals that cyclists are not expected or welcome, discouraging the short trips by bike that are often the most practical way to access corridor businesses from nearby residential streets. Installing bike racks at regular intervals along Bustleton Avenue, particularly in front of commercial clusters and at transit stops, would cost little, require minimal infrastructure, and send a clear signal that the corridor is becoming more multimodal. The Philadelphia Streets Department's bike parking program should be approached to conduct the installation, involving bike advocacy groups like Bicycle coalition and finally approaching business owners to sponsor or co-locate racks adjacent to storefronts would make this a viable intervention to improve the corridor. The first pilot program would identify 6-8 potential locations and conduct installation. The second phase of bike storage would be post streetscape improvements, the completion of bike lanes and sidewalks and would incorporate learnings from the pilot.

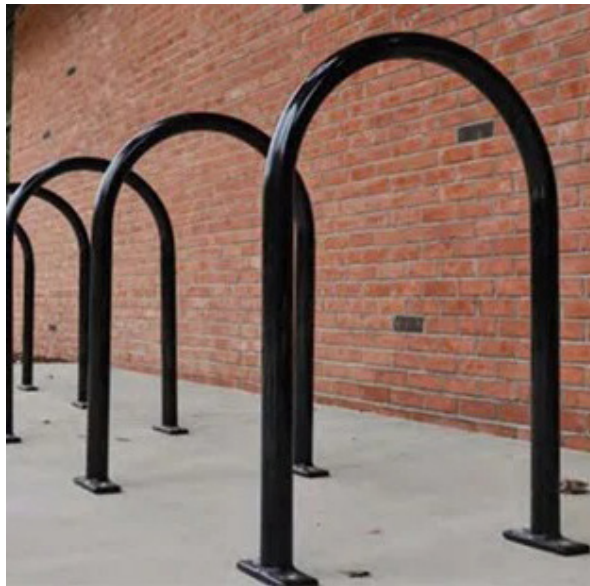
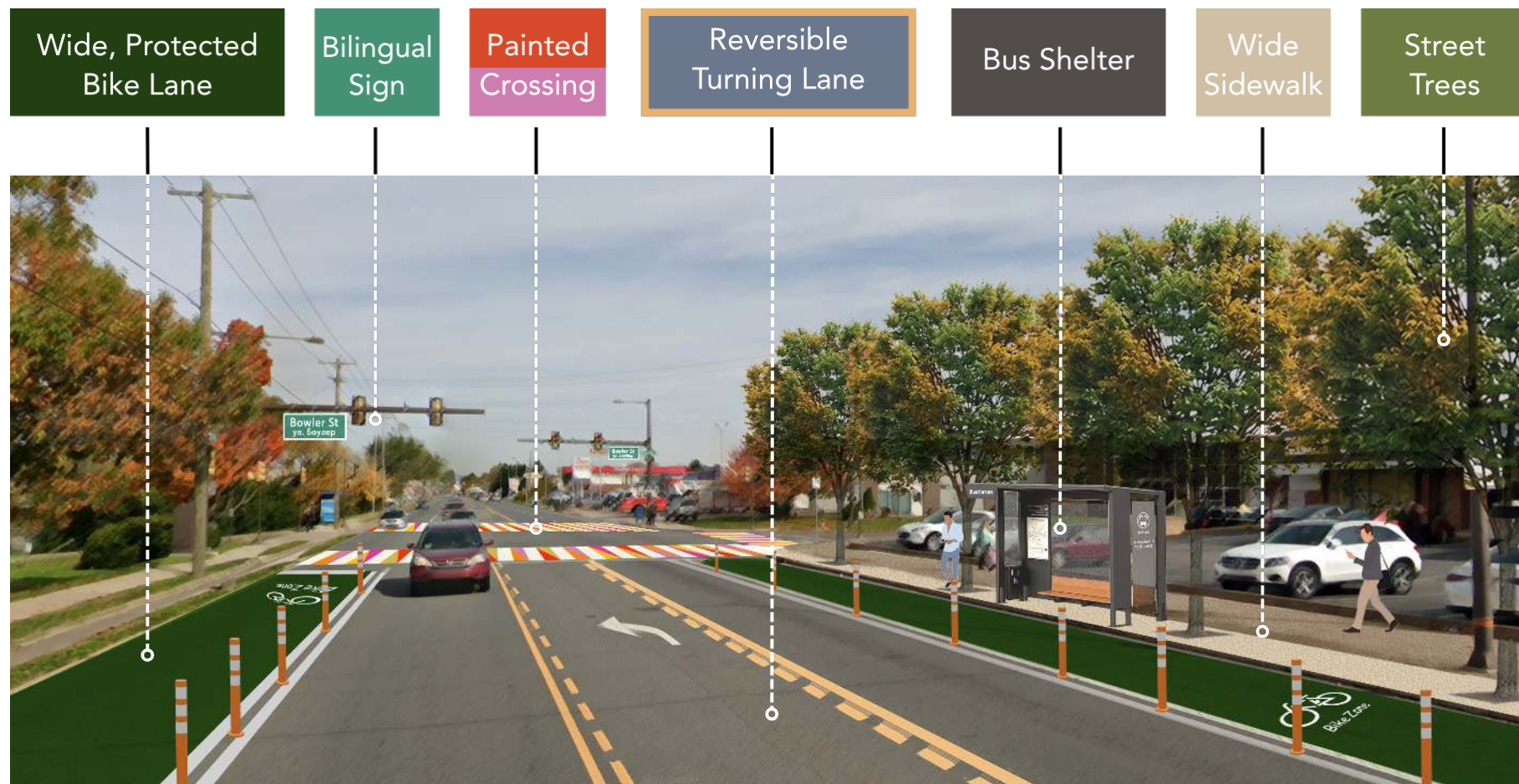


FIG.42 IMAGE OF BIKE STORAGE, CREDIT: BICYCLE COALITION OF GREATER PHILADELPHIA.



FIG.43 BIKES LEANING AGAINST BUSTLETON DUNKIN DONUTS DRIVE THRU (GOOGLE STREET VIEW)

FIG.44 RENDERING OF PROPOSED BUSTLETON AVENUE



Bustleton Avenue serves as a major commercial corridor but currently prioritizes vehicle throughput over pedestrian safety and comfort. With approximately 25,000 vehicles traveling the corridor daily, high traffic volumes contribute to speeding, unsafe crossings, and a less inviting environment for shoppers and residents. Implementing traffic calming measures is essential to improving safety, reducing crash risk, and supporting the corridor's economic vitality.

Recommendation 2.1: Create a road diet on Bustleton Ave

Recommendation 2.2: Add protected bike lanes

Recommendation 2.3: Enforce the speed limit

Recommendation 2.4: Install Curb Extensions

Recommendation 2.5: Redesign the bridge above Haldeman Ave

Recommendation 2.1

Recommend a Road Diet on Bustleton Avenue

A road diet at Bustleton Avenue and Grant Avenue would reduce lane widths or the number of travel lanes, reallocating space for safer multimodal use. Complementary interventions such as high-visibility, colorful crosswalks near commercial centers would improve pedestrian safety and increase driver awareness, while protected bike lanes along the avenue would create safer conditions for cyclists and encourage alternative transportation. Public engagement and coordination between Philadelphia's Department of Streets the Pennsylvania Department of Transportation are important first-steps before implementation can happen. Together, these measures would transform the corridor into a more balanced, accessible, and economically vibrant main street.

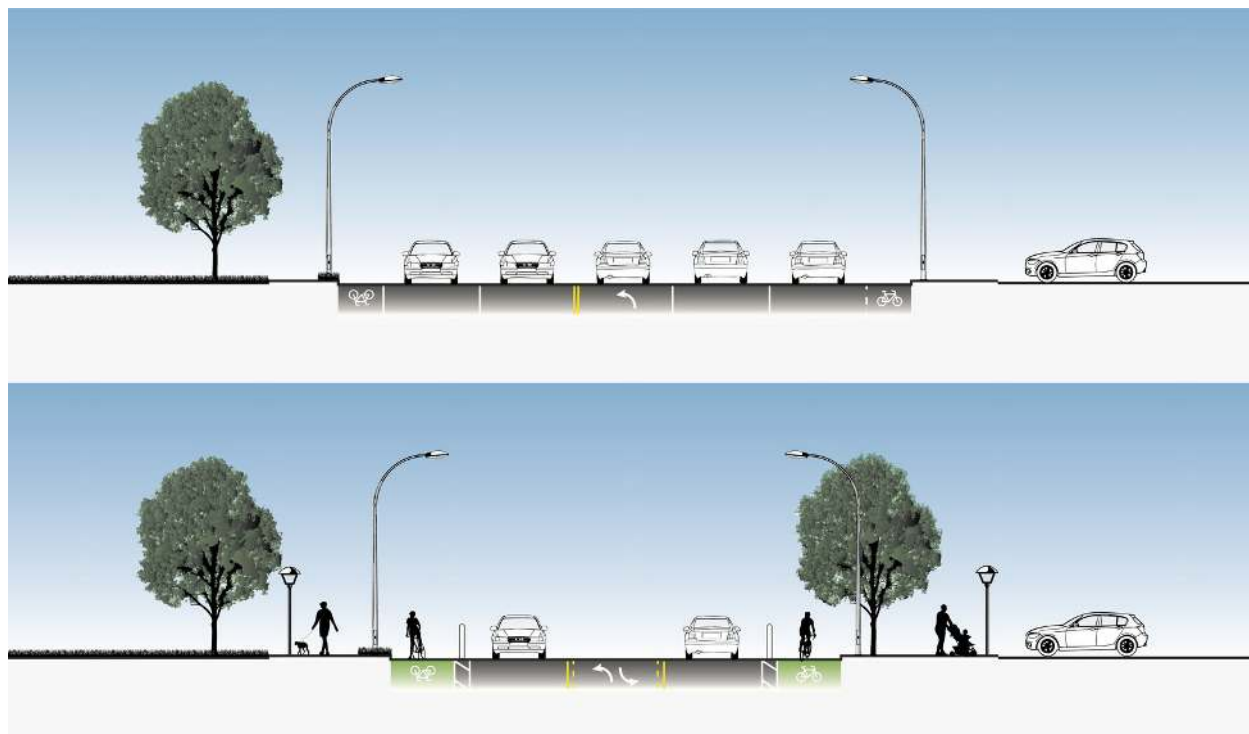


FIG.45 BEFORE AND AFTER OF BUSTLETON AVE AND BOWLER ST. INTERSECTION POST THE INTRODUCTION OF THE ROAD DIET.

PRIORITY
High

COST
\$\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE

Mid - Long

ENTITIES

Streets dept

+ PennDOT

+ OTIS

PRIORITY High

COST \$\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE

Mid - Long

ENTITIES

Streets dept

+ PennDOT
+ OTIS

Recommendation 2.2

Add Protected Bike Lanes on Bustleton Avenue, Grant Avenue, & Welsh Road

The addition of protected bike lanes on both Bustleton Ave and major intersecting streets such as Grant Avenue and Welsh Road will create a cycling network in the neighborhood, making biking safer and more accessible to all residents. Currently, these roads are designated as moderate to highly stressful for cyclists by the DVRPC, as the painted bike lanes offer little protection from the high volume of car traffic on these roads. The construction of bike lanes on Grant Avenue and Welsh Road should ideally occur simultaneously with the road diet-related construction on Bustleton Ave, in order to limit construction-related disruptions for residents.



FIG.46 PROTECTED BIKE LANES IN COLUMBUS, OH, CREDIT: NACTO.ORG



FIG.47 MAP DEPICTING HIGH TRAFFIC STRESS ON CYCLISTS

Recommendation 2.3

Enforce the Speed Limit

Although Bustleton Avenue currently has a relatively low speed limit of 30 miles per hour, the presence of speed bumps and the avenue's designation as part of the High Injury Network point to speeding as an issue. Ensuring low traffic speeds is fundamental to ensuring the safety of both cyclists and pedestrians. The installation of speed cameras and radar signs will help enforce the speed limit and keep risky drivers accountable. The City of Philadelphia has already installed speed cameras along other arterial roads such as Roosevelt Boulevard and Broad Street, so we propose that Bustleton Avenue be added to this existing network of speed camera surveillance.



FIG.48 CURRENT SPEED LIMIT ENFORCEMENT MEASURES ON BUSTLETON AVE.



FIG.49 PROPOSED SPEED LIMIT ENFORCEMENT THROUGH CAMERAS, CREDIT: WHY

PRIORITY
High

COST
\$\$ - \$\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short

ENTITIES
Streets dept
+ Philadelphia Parking Authority (PPA)

PRIORITY
High

COST
\$\$ - \$\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Mid

ENTITIES
Streets dept

Recommendation 2.4 Install Curb Extensions

Curb extensions should be installed at important intersections along Bustleton Avenue in coordination with high-visibility crosswalks to promote pedestrian safety. The cost of installations can vary greatly based on whether the curb extensions are painted or include physical barriers, but because we are proposing other traffic calming elements in tandem, these curb extensions likely will not require physical barriers in order to be effective.

CASE STUDY

Curb Extensions

Location: Long Beach, CA

*Entity: City of Long Beach Public Works
Department & Arts Council Long Beach*

Year: 2023

Cost: \$25,500



Description: Before the City intervened, the four-way intersection at 15th Street and Chestnut Avenue in Long Beach was the site of multiple accidents and speeding. By reaching out to the public for input and commissioning artists to design colorful curb extensions, Long Beach was able to reduce speeds and improve pedestrian safety at this intersection.

Lesson for Bustleton: This intervention was a relatively low-cost solution for a serious problem that succeeded in engaging the community, adding to neighborhood character, and addressing issues of traffic safety.

FIG.50 CURB EXTENSTIONS LONG
BEACH, CA

Recommendation 2.5

Redesign the Bridge above Haldeman Ave

Bustleton Avenue is somewhat divided by the bridge section between Haldeman Avenue and Norwalk Road. Rather than continue the same road diet design along this portion of Bustleton Avenue, we propose the widening of both the center median and the sidewalks, as well as the continuation of the protected bike lanes. This is because there is no need for a bidirectional turning lane during this section of the avenue. These changes will ensure the continued walkability and bikeability of Bustleton Avenue throughout its entire length in the neighborhood, guaranteeing pedestrian access to the residents of the Paul's Run Retirement Community to both the Einstein Center One medical center and Presidential Plaza on the other side of the bridge.

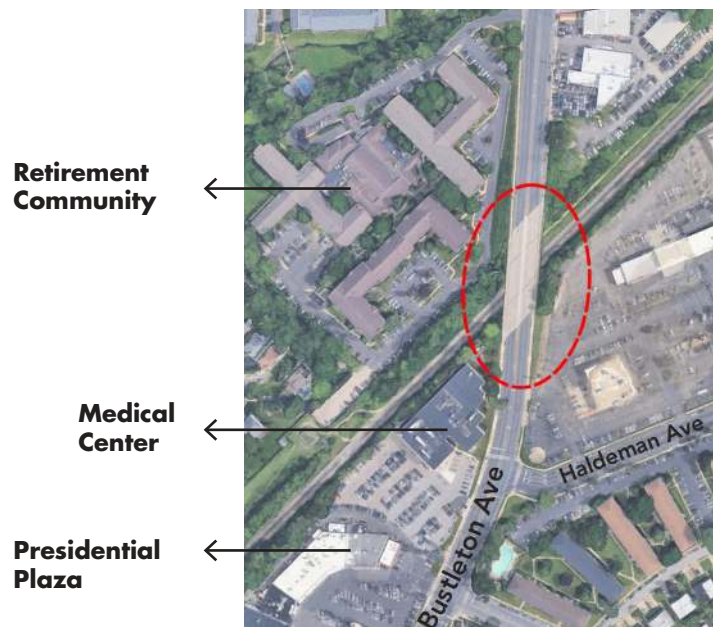


FIG.51 LOCATION OF PROPOSED BRIDGE REDESIGN BETWEEN HALDERMAN AVE AND BUSTLETON AVE



FIG.52 PROPOSED CHANGES TO IMPROVE WALKABILITY ACROSS THE RAMP

PRIORITY
Medium

COST
\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Mid

ENTITIES
Streets dept

+ PennDOT
+ OTIS

Improving public transportation infrastructure and service along Bustleton Avenue is essential to increasing accessibility and reducing reliance on cars. While the corridor is served by bus routes, existing facilities and service levels may not adequately meet the needs of residents, particularly those who depend on transit for daily travel.

Installing additional bus shelters would improve rider comfort and protection from the elements, while digital signage providing real-time arrival information would enhance reliability and user experience. Increasing bus frequency along Bustleton Avenue would reduce wait times and make transit a more attractive option. Together, these improvements would support greater transit use and contribute to a more sustainable transportation system.

Recommendation 3.1: Install bus shelters

Recommendation 3.2: Improve bus frequency

Recommendation 3.3: Add digital signage for bus stops without shelters

Recommendation 3.1

Install Bus Shelters

Bustleton Avenue has a low number of bus shelters at its stops, with currently only one at Bustleton and Bowler near the Municipal Building. We recommend that all the bus stops in front of commercial strips on Bustleton Ave be retrofitted with bus shelters, in order to support the use of public transportation along the avenue and reinforce the walkability of the commercial corridor in combination with the proposed streetscape and road diet changes. Partnerships with SEPTA and local community organizations could help identify prime bus stops with high ridership as additional candidates for bus shelter installations. In total, these additional shelters would improve the comfort for bus riders in the neighborhood, particularly for aging residents.

**New Bus Shelters Near
Commercial Areas**

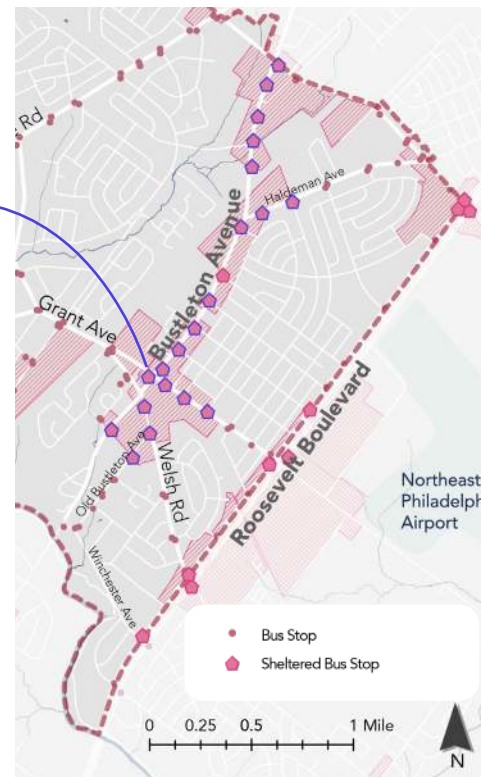


FIG.53 PROPOSED BUS SHELTERS
ALONG BUSTLETON AVE

PRIORITY
High

COST
\$\$ - \$\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE

Short - Mid

ENTITIES

Streets dept

+ Southeastern
Pennsylvania
Transportation Authority
(SEPTA)

PRIORITY

Medium

COST

\$\$ - \$\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE

Short - Mid

ENTITIES

Streets dept

+ SEPTA

Recommendation 3.2

Install Digital Signage at Bus Stops

At existing SEPTA bus stops in our study area, the addition of digital real-time signage could provide riders with wait times and rerouting notifications to further improve the comfort and transparency for bus riders in the neighborhood. Digital signage with real-time information will be especially important for elderly residents in the neighborhood, who often don't utilize transit apps or websites on their phones for navigation. We recognize that this is a city-wide issue and that SEPTA is currently piloting a digital signage initiative, so implementation of these signs in Bustleton will be dependent on the results of this pilot program.

CASE STUDY

MBTA Digital Signage

Location: Boston, MA

Entity: Massachusetts Bay Transportation Authority

Year: 2017

Cost: \$20,000 per sign



Description: In 2017, the MBTA started piloting solar-powered, digital signage for their streetcar and bus stops. These “E-ink” signs are cheaper than traditional, more bulky screens and easier to install.

Lesson for Bustleton: SEPTA is currently planning to start a digital signage pilot. By organizing residents, neighborhood organizations in Bustleton can help advocate for the installation of these signs at important bus stops in the neighborhood.

FIG.54 “E-INK” SOLAR-POWERED SIGNAGE

Recommendation 3.3

Improve SEPTA Bus Frequency

As a reminder, 14% of Bustleton residents do not have access to a personal vehicle. The aforementioned ridership data from 2017-2024 suggests that bus route 14 is a popular route in the neighborhood, but the current frequency does not match that demand. Promoting bus route 14 to SEPTA's Frequent Network would therefore better serve the neighborhood's needs. Furthermore, increasing the frequency of bus route 88 to every 30 minutes or less would provide residents with better transit access to the Bethayres regional rail station. Increasing the frequency and efficiency of bus route 88 would thus connect bus riders in the neighborhood with job and education opportunities in the nearby suburbs and Center City Philadelphia more efficiently.



Every 30 Minutes → Every 15 Minutes



Every >30 Minutes → Every 15-30 Minutes

PRIORITY
Medium

COST
\$\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Long

ENTITIES
SEPTA
+ OTIS

Rezoning parcels adjacent to Bustleton Avenue, Grant Avenue, and Welsh Road would support higher-density, mixed-use development and better align land use with the corridor's role as a commercial and transit spine. Much of the existing zoning reflects auto-oriented suburban patterns, which limits opportunities for housing growth and economic activity. Strategic rezoning can unlock underutilized sites and encourage more efficient, pedestrian-friendly development.

This strategy includes promoting long-term mixed-use redevelopment of aging shopping plazas and transitioning auto-oriented parcels to CMX zoning overlay. These changes would incentivize developments that combine residential, retail, and community uses, creating a more dynamic and walkable environment. Over time, increased density would support local businesses, improve housing supply, and strengthen the overall viability of the corridor.

Recommendation 4.1: Upzone Bustleton Ave for Mixed-use Multifamily Housing

Recommendation 4.2: Allow for infill development in residential areas near Bustleton Avenue

Recommendation 4.3: Convert Auto-Oriented Development to CMX Zoning

Recommendation 4.4: Incentivize Affordable Housing

Recommendation 4.1

Upzone Bustleton Ave for Mixed-use Multifamily Housing

Bustleton Avenue should be upzoned to allow up to a 3x increase in density by right, with buildings up to five stories. Additionally, this plan recommends requiring ground-floor retail along Bustleton Ave to reinforce it as the commercial avenue and improve walkability. Consultation with the Bustleton Neighborhood Association and RCOs as a developer mandate should be prioritized, but approvals by-right should be kept to avoid added uncertainty. The goal is to increase housing supply through predictability.

PRIORITY
High

COST
-

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short - Mid

ENTITIES
**Zoning
Board of
Adjustments**

+ City Council
+ City Planning
Commission
+ Neighborhood
Associations



FIG.55 PRESENT TYPOLOGY OF MULTIFAMILY DEVELOPMENT ON BUSTLETON AVE



FIG.56 EXAMPLE OF PROPOSED MID-RISE DEVELOPMENTS, CREDIT: MONTGOMERY PLANNING, D.C.

PRIORITY

Medium

COST

-

GOALS



TIMELINE

Short - Mid

ENTITIES

**Zoning
Board of
Adjustments**

- + City Council
- + City Planning Commission
- + Neighborhood Associations

Recommendation 4.2**Allow for Infill Development in Residential Areas near Bustleton Avenue**

Duplexes, triplexes, fourplexes, townhomes, and ADUs should be permitted by right within a defined transition area near Bustleton Ave, with density bonuses and streamlined approvals for small-scale multifamily. Using form-based standards should be utilized to maintain neighborhood character while enabling infill and paired with incentives for conversions of existing homes to support aging in place and preserve naturally occurring affordable housing.



FIG.57 PRESENT TYPOLOGY OF HOUSING STOCK WHICH IS PRIMARILY SINGLE DETACHED HOMES



FIG.58 NEWER CONDOMINIUMS ALONG PRESIDENT ST.

Recommendation 4.3

Convert Auto-Oriented Development to CMX zoning

This recommendation calls for the rezoning of underutilized, auto-oriented sites to CMX to enable mixed-use development along Bustleton Ave. Additionally, first-floor retail with residential above should be emphasized, consistent with the overall corridor strategy. This recommendation is about allowing gradual, market-driven redevelopment over time, not forcing immediate change. The zoning should be in place ahead of that transition so that these sites can evolve into more walkable, higher-density nodes as opportunities arise.

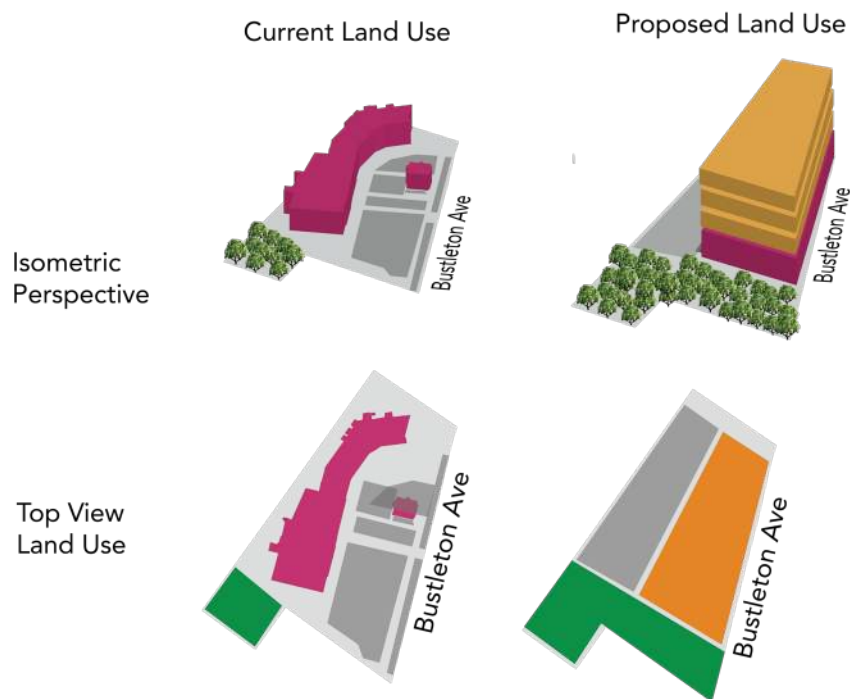


FIG.59 ISOMETRIC MASSING OF POTENTIAL MIXED-USE REDEVELOPMENT OF PRESIDENTIAL

PRIORITY
High

COST
-

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short - Mid

ENTITIES
**Zoning
Board of
Adjustments**

+ City Council
+ City Planning
Commission
+ Neighborhood
Associations

PRIORITY
High

COST
-

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short - Mid

ENTITIES
**Zoning
Board of
Adjustments**

- + City Council
- + City Planning Commission
- + Neighborhood Associations

Recommendation 4.4 Create an Affordable Housing Overlay

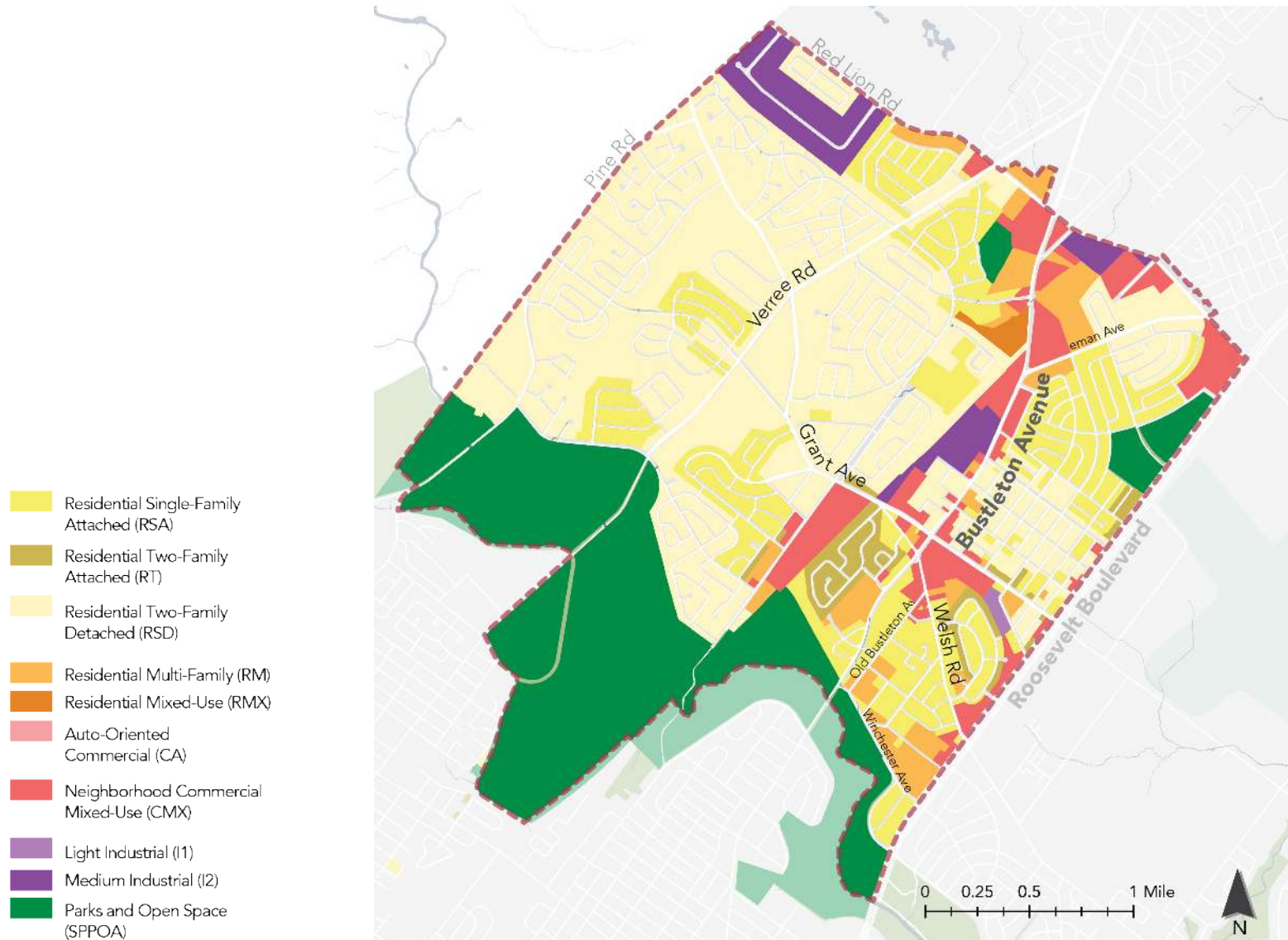
A zoning overlay should be created that ties additional density directly to long-term affordability. Projects providing units at 80% AMI and below, with a minimum 30-year affordability period, should receive automatic density bonuses and by-right approval. The broader AMI range reflects Bustleton's higher median income while still addressing cost-burden and partially addressing some of the concerns from the Mixed Income Neighborhood Overlay District in the 3rd, 4th and 7th districts of Philadelphia. RCO engagement will be maintained but shifted to a rules-based system. If a project meets the requirements, it moves forward. This increases the likelihood that affordable units are actually built.



**1 bedroom
~\$2500**

FIG.60 AN APARTMENT COMPLEX WITH HIGH RENTAL PRICES ACCORDING TO APARTMENTS.COM

FIG.61 PROPOSED ZONING MAP



Expanding and preserving affordable housing in Bustleton is essential to maintaining socioeconomic diversity and preventing displacement as the neighborhood evolves. Increasing mixed-use multifamily housing along Bustleton Avenue, Welsh Road, and Grant Avenue through targeted upzoning would create opportunities for new housing supply in areas well-served by transit and amenities.

Incentive-based approaches—such as density bonuses or inclusionary zoning—can encourage developers to include affordable units in new projects. Additionally, promoting a wider variety of housing types, including smaller units and accessible housing, would better meet the needs of different household types, including seniors, young professionals, and immigrant families. Together, these strategies would help ensure that Bustleton remains an inclusive and affordable community.

Targeted housing assistance programs can help existing residents maintain and improve their homes, particularly in a neighborhood with an aging housing stock. A housing maintenance program would provide financial or technical assistance for repairs, helping prevent deterioration and preserving neighborhood quality.

Recommendation 5.1: Connect Residents with Existing Housing Programs

Recommendation 5.2: Connect Residents with Aging-in-Place Programs

Recommendation 5.3: Support Home Energy Efficiency Upgrades

Recommendation 5.1

Connect Residents with Existing Housing Programs

Neighborhood organizations and the CDC should help increase the awareness and utilization of existing City of Philadelphia repair, weatherization, and preservation programs among small landlords and homeowners. Hands-on technical assistance should be provided to help property owners navigate applications, compliance requirements, and financing options, with targeted outreach in areas with aging multifamily stock. The goal is to make it easier to access existing resources, reduce deferred maintenance, and preserve naturally occurring affordable housing without relying solely on new programs.

Relevant Current Programs:

Basic Systems Repair Program (BSRP) + Adaptive Modifications Program (AMP) - These can support existing small multifamily and homeowners adding units by maintaining baseline housing quality.

Weatherization Assistance Program (WAP) - Focuses on insulation, heating efficiency, and energy cost reduction.

Restore, Repair, Renew (RRR) Program - Offers low-interest loans for broader home improvements beyond emergency repairs.

Philadelphia Housing Trust Fund - Provides funding for both preservation and production programs, including repairs and stabilization.



FIG.62 THE H.O.M.E INITIATIVE A PHILADELPHIA CITY PROGRAM, CREDIT: H.O.M.E INITIATIVE LANDING PAGE

Supported by H.O.M.E.

The H.O.M.E. Plan addresses these key priorities. Expand each category to see the new and existing h



Production: Affordable housing



Preservation: Housing repairs & modifications



Incentives: Community impact



Stabilization: Assistance for homeowners & renters



Pre-development: Land use & contractor training

FIG.63 ASPECTS OF THE H.O.M.E INITIATIVE THAT CAN BE USEFUL FOR HOMEOWNER, CREDIT: H.O.M.E INITIATIVE LANDING PAGE

PRIORITY
High

COST
-

GOALS



TIMELINE
Mid - Long

ENTITIES
Neighborhood Associations

+ City
+ Community
Development
Corporation (CDC)

PRIORITY

Medium

COST

-

GOALS



TIMELINE

Mid - Long

ENTITIES

Neighborhood Associations

+ Philadelphia
Corporation for the
Aging (PCA)

Recommendation 5.2

Connect Residents with Aging-In-Place Programs

Neighborhood organizations like Kleinlife can work with the CDC to establish a centralized, neighborhood-based system that connects seniors to existing City of Philadelphia programs for home repairs, accessibility upgrades, tax relief, and supportive services, paired with hands-on navigation assistance to help residents apply and participate. The focus should be on proactive outreach rather than passive availability, and integrating housing, healthcare, and mobility services into a coordinated network so residents can remain in their homes as they age.

Relevant Current Programs :

Senior Tax Freeze Program - Helps stabilize housing costs for long-term homeowners on fixed incomes.

Longtime Owner Occupants Program (LOOP) - Protects homeowners from displacement due to rising property taxes

Adaptive Modifications Program (AMP) - Funds accessibility improvements such as ramps, stair lifts, and bathroom modifications.

Philadelphia Corporation for Aging (PCA) - Provides support services that complement housing interventions, including in-home care and assistance.



FIG.64 CREDIT: PAUL'S RUN RETIREMENT COMMUNITY

Recommendation 5.3

Support Home Energy Efficiency Programs

Neighborhood organizations can work with the CDC to structure a neighborhood-based grant program modeled similarly to a Block Challenge Grant, where funding is deployed at the block level once a minimum number of homeowners commit to improvements. The grants can be used to support insulation, air sealing, HVAC upgrades, and window replacement, paired with technical assistance to help residents access existing City of Philadelphia and utility programs. This approach builds participation, reduces costs through coordination, and enables visible, block-by-block reinvestment in aging housing stock.



Built to Last

Philadelphia has an abundant supply of affordable housing compared to our peer cities. But high poverty rates, rising maintenance and utility costs, and an aging housing stock make ownership increasingly difficult to sustain.

Philadelphia's government agencies, utilities, and non-profit service providers offer various housing repair and energy affordability programs. Often, however, those facing the greatest challenges are deemed ineligible for services.

Among the nation's 10 most populous cities, Philadelphia has the highest proportion of cost-burdened, low-income households.

Built to Last coordinates and supplements existing programs, simplifying the process for low-income homeowners to navigate complex systems. In doing so, Built to Last ensures a whole-home approach to housing preservation, combining health, safety, and energy efficiency improvements.

The PEA-led program aggregates available funding to fill project gaps and sequences improvements. Our approach overcomes barriers to program eligibility, prevents housing displacement, and addresses unhealthy housing conditions. Where possible, Built to Last prioritizes high-efficiency upgrades and low-cost renewable energy. We are a proud ENERGY STAR Home Upgrade partner.

FIG.65 CREDIT: BUILT TO LAST LANDING PAGE.

PRIORITY
Medium

COST
-

GOALS



TIMELINE
Mid - Long

ENTITIES
Neighborhood Associations

+ Philadelphia Energy Authority (PEA)

Many commercial properties along Bustleton Avenue consist of aging, auto-oriented shopping centers with underutilized space and vacant storefronts. Reinvesting in these properties is critical to revitalizing the corridor and supporting local economic growth.

Strategies could include incentivizing property owners to renovate and modernize storefronts, as well as implementing programs to activate vacant spaces through temporary uses such as pop-ups or community events. Encouraging adaptive reuse and redevelopment of these sites would create more engaging, pedestrian-friendly environments while attracting new businesses. Over time, these efforts would strengthen the commercial corridor and enhance Bustleton's economic resilience.

Recommendation 6.1: Encourage Facade Improvements

Recommendation 6.2: Activate Vacant Land on Bustleton Ave

Recommendation 6.3: Activate Vacant Storefronts

Recommendation 6.1

Support Facade Improvements

The Philadelphia Department of Commerce supports many commercial corridors in the city in their storefront improvement program. Though Bustleton Avenue is not currently distinguished to be a corridor on which they are offering the program, Bustleton community groups and government officials could approach the Department of Commerce for opportunities for storefront improvement on the Bustleton Avenue Corridor.

Facades of shopping centers could be improved through facade cleaning, bright paint application, window clearing and washing, outdoor seating, and improved signage. An example of a successfully inviting storefront renovation is Chickpeas Mediterranean Grill near Bowler and Bustleton, where business owners painted the facade bright yellow, added a new sign, and invested in cheap but colorful seating both inside and outside. Facade improvements create an inviting environment, welcoming residents and visitors to enter establishments and spend their money.



FIG.66 TACTICAL FACADE IMPROVEMENTS AT CHICKPEA'S



FIG.67 A SIMPLE FACADE IMPROVEMENT PROJECT FROM BALTIMORE, MD, CREDIT: MARYLAND.GOV

PRIORITY
High

COST
\$ - \$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Mid

ENTITIES
Dept of Commerce

+ Local Businesses

PRIORITY

Medium

COST

\$

GOALS



TIMELINE

Short

ENTITIES

**Philadelphia
Horticultural
Society**

Recommendation 6.2

Activate Vacant Land

The Pennsylvania Horticultural Society has been cleaning and improving vacant land throughout Philadelphia through their Transforming Vacant Land program for multiple decades. Two main vacant lots have been identified along Bustleton Avenue at 1736 Welsh Rd, Philadelphia, PA 19115 and 9368-70 Old Bustleton Ave, Philadelphia, PA 19115.

Though there is not a great deal of vacant land in the Bustleton Avenue corridor, it could be stabilized and improved to include fencing and trees. There is also the opportunity to incorporate outdoor furniture and large planters. This program helps to beautify vacant lots, making these spaces more attractive for neighbors that may be walking or driving by.



FIG.68 AN EXAMPLE OF A VACANT LOT STABILIZED BY THE PHILADELPHIA HORTICULTURAL SOCIETY, CREDIT: PHS.

Recommendation 6.3

Activate Vacant Storefronts

There are a handful of vacant storefronts along Bustleton Avenue, including 9708 Bustleton Avenue and 1910 Welsh Road. These sites could be good opportunities for pop-up installations that could activate the storefronts and create cohesion along the corridor. Neighborhood organizations and the CDC could work together to fundraise for the activation of these storefronts, depending on the kind of activation that is deemed appropriate for each site. Other strips in the city that experience vacancy, including Kensington Avenue, have implemented arts programming in vacant storefront windows. The arts attract passersby and connect corridors between open businesses.

CASE STUDY

“Vacant to Vibrant”

San Francisco, CA
2023



FIG.69 A SMALL BUSINESS SUPPORTED VACANT TO VIBRANT, CREDIT: VACANT TO VIBRANT, SF NEW DEAL.

Description: Vacant to Vibrant was launched as a pilot in 2023 in order to revitalize vacant storefronts in Downtown San Francisco. The program is now permanent, granting small businesses funding for pop-up events in vacant spaces as well as supporting the long-term establishment of some of these businesses by providing business owners support with permitting and lease negotiation.

Lesson for Bustleton: Pop-up events can boost the local economy and help new small businesses establish themselves in the neighborhood, reinforcing the neighborhood's economic vitality.

PRIORITY
Medium

COST
\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short

ENTITIES
**Commerce
dept**
+ Local Businesses
+ CDC

Bustleton's cultural diversity is one of its greatest assets, particularly its strong immigrant communities and small business ecosystem. Promoting this diversity through targeted cultural and economic initiatives can strengthen neighborhood identity, support local entrepreneurs, and attract visitors from across the region.

Recommendations include installing road signage in prominent immigrant languages to improve accessibility and reflect community identity, as well as organizing multicultural food tours to showcase local businesses and cuisines. Recognizing places like the Budd Factory as a cultural landmark would further reinforce the neighborhood's historical and cultural significance. These efforts would not only celebrate Bustleton's diversity but also drive economic activity and community pride.

Recommendation 7.1: Install Road Signs in Prominent Immigrant Languages

Recommendation 7.2: Organize Multicultural Food Tour

Recommendation 7.3: Install Cultural Landmark Signage

Recommendation 7.4: Establish a Farmers Market and Parking Lot Pop-ups

Recommendation 7.5: Expand Mural Network

Recommendation 7.1

Road Signs in Prominent Immigrant Languages

Based on US Census Bureau ACS 5-year data, 36% of Bustleton residents were born in a different country. This is seen in the diverse food scene, private business signage, and immigrant supporting organizations in the area—where Ukrainian, Russian, Albanian, Georgian, Uzbek, and Malayalam are on display. This recommendation is geared at creating a welcoming environment for existing residents, new residents, and visitors to the multicultural nature of the Bustleton community. Based on place of birth for foreign born, it is recommended that Ukrainian and Russian are best for the multilingual language, followed by Malayalam and Uzbek. In terms of language spoken at home Census data, 14% Indo-European language groups speak English less than “very well,” which includes Ukrainian and Russian, whereas 8% of Asian and Pacific Islander language speakers speak English less than “very well,” including Uzbek and Malayalam.

The signage could be centered near main intersections, such as the intersections of Bustleton Ave and Winchester Avenue, Welsh Road, Grant Avenue, Bowler Street, Haldeman Avenue, Norwalk Road, Red Lion Road. This could take the form of an alternative street naming process, similar to that seen in other parts of Philadelphia, where City Councilmembers lobby to add additional street names in red and white to the bottom of our green and white street signs.

The process would entail a community engagement process with community groups, including the Greater Bustleton Civic Association, New World Association, and the Kleinlife Center. These community organizations could engage residents and business owners to decide on the primary languages besides English in Bustleton. The Coalition of community groups could approach City Council, including Council President Kenyatta Johnson and District 10 Councilmember Brian O’Neill to pass a special resolution to add additional road signage.



FIG.70 MULTILINGUAL SIGNAGE FROM CHINATOWN IN NYC, CREDIT: NYT



FIG.71 MULTILINGUAL SIGNAGE FROM BRIGHTON BEACH, CREDIT: UNTAPPED CITIES

PRIORITY
Medium

COST
\$ - \$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short

ENTITIES
Streets dept

+ Neighborhood Associations

PRIORITY

MediumCOST
\$

GOALS



TIMELINE

Recurring

ENTITIES

**Neighborhood
Associations**+ Greater Northeast
Philadelphia Chamber
of Commerce

Recommendation 7.2

Organize Multicultural Food Tour

The Greater Bustleton Civic Association, New World Association, and Kleinlife could collaborate on developing a food tour in Bustleton. The tour would partner with local businesses to prepare small plates for food tour attendees, charging a small fee to participants to be distributed amongst the participating businesses.

The food tour could be multicultural through the participation of local businesses representing cuisines from various cultures. The tour could showcase the Uzbek, Russian, Ukrainian, Georgian, Indian, Latin, and African foods in the Bustleton area, highlighting the diverse mix of identities in Bustleton and supporting the strong local business scene in the neighborhood. These food tours could be large community events held annually, similar to Center City's Restaurant Week.

Food businesses that could be included on the food tour:

Plov House, Uzbek food, 9969 Bustleton Ave, Philadelphia, PA

Tandoori Market, Uzbek Grocery, 842 Red Lion Rd Store 20, Philadelphia, PA

Petrovsky Market, Russian Grocery, 9808 Bustleton Ave # L, Philadelphia, PA

Asante African Supermarket, African Grocery, 9817 Bustleton Ave, Philadelphia, PA

Cafe Maestro, Georgian Food, 1900 Grant Ave # D, Philadelphia, PA

Kazka Cafe, Ukrainian Food, 1916 Welsh Rd, Philadelphia, PA

Don Pedro Meats and Market 2, Latin Grocery, 1916 Welsh Rd #16, Philadelphia, PA

Kuttanad Hypermarket, Indian Grocery, 9271 Alton St, Philadelphia, PA

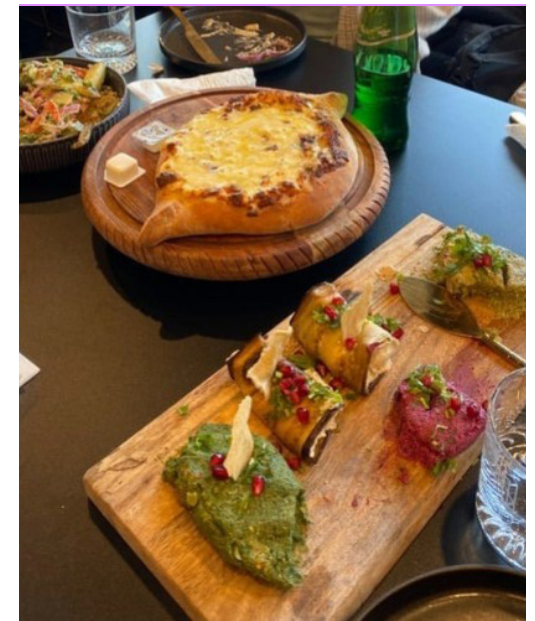


FIG.72 FOOD AT MAESTRO CAFE, A GEORGIAN RESTAURANT

Recommendation 7.3

Install Cultural Landmark Signage

Bustleton has a rich history as a farming community with a small main street core along Bustleton Avenue dating to before the American Revolutionary War. The notable buildings and landmarks in the area would be commemorated through this tactic, which would look to highlight Bustleton's rich history as a neighborhood with various long established religious communities, businesses, manufacturers, and mills, and key regional infrastructure. Additionally, the historical signage could help new residents as they orient themselves to Bustleton and its connection to the greater Philadelphia region.

Historical neighborhood markers could be established and maintained through partnerships with the Philadelphia Historical Commission, a city agency, and the Preservation Alliance, a public-private funder.

Recommended sites for cultural fact signage include:

Budd Co, Red Lion Plant, 600 Red Lion Rd, Philadelphia, PA 19116

Bustleton Tavern and Hotel, 9372 Old Bustleton Ave, Philadelphia, PA

Bustleton Train Line, 1736 Welsh Rd, Philadelphia, PA

Pennepack Baptist Church, 8732 Krewstown Rd, Philadelphia, PA

The old Maternity BVM Church, Bustleton Avenue &, Winchester Ave

Verree House, Verree Rd & Bloomfield Av

Pennypack Creek Covered Bridge, 9032 Old Bustleton Ave, Philadelphia, PA



FIG.73 HISTORICAL MARKERS FOUND AROUND PHILADELPHIA, CREDIT: BILLY PENN.

PRIORITY
Medium

COST
\$ - \$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Mid

ENTITIES
CDC

+ Neighborhood Associations
+ Historical Commission
+ Preservation Alliance

PRIORITY High

COST \$

GOALS



TIMELINE

Recurring

ENTITIES

The Food Trust

+ CDC

Recommendation 7.4 Establish a Farmers Market and Parking Lot Pop-ups

Much of the commercial spaces along Bustleton Ave are divided from the street by large parking lots. Many of these parking lots never reach capacity, making them prime locations for interventions, including outdoor seating, farmers' market spaces, and various pop-up events. Local vendors and existing businesses could bring their commerce outdoors seasonally and on special occasions.

Farmers Markets provide fresh produce from local farms to residents in a host community. The benefits of a farmers' market are a connection to local and regional food sources, a financial benefit to local farmers, and a health benefit for area residents. In Philadelphia, many farmers' markets are managed by the Food Trust, a local nonprofit organization that aims to provide healthy food access in many parts of the city. The Food Trust does not currently have a presence in the Far Northeast, making Bustleton a prime location to host a market that brings fresh local produce to the area. We suggest the farmers market is hosted in the Presidential Plaza parking lot (9806 Bustleton Ave), which has plenty of space for a market and parking on Bustleton Avenue. This central location could attract residents walking and driving by on the main thoroughfare. Also, Belair Shopping Center has plenty of space for hosting outdoor seating and markets as well.



FIG.74 RENDERING OF PROPOSED FARMER'S MARKET AND POP-UP EVENTS IN THE BELAIR SHOPPING CENTER.

Recommendation 7.5

Expand Mural Network

Murals are a distinct Philadelphia artform that helps to beautiful and tell stories of the city's communities. Bustleton is a fantastic neighborhood in which to expand the existing mural network in the city, as it has many commercial spaces with black walls that are ripe for color and imagery.

There is one existing mural on either side of the PAWS Northeast Philly location at Bustleton and Grant Avenues. From this site, we suggest expanding the mural network to the following Bustleton locations in conjunction with Mural Arts, shopping center owners, the Philadelphia School District, and local businesses:

- USTC's Red Tiger Taekwon-do, 1912 Welsh Rd, Philadelphia, PA 19115
- Maternity BVM School, 9322 Old Bustleton Ave, Philadelphia, PA 19115
- Chickpeas Mediterranean Grill, 9813 Bustleton Ave, Philadelphia, PA 19115
- MultiCook, 9831 Bustleton Ave #6, Philadelphia, PA 19115
- Bustleton Avenue Municipal Building, Bowler St, Philadelphia, PA 19115
- The Shops at Red Lion, 9996 Bustleton Ave, Philadelphia, PA 19115
- CCA Baldi Middle School, 8801 Verree Rd, Philadelphia, PA 19115
- Greenberg Elementary School, 600 Sharon Ln, Philadelphia, PA 19115



FIG.75 IDENTIFIED SITE THAT COULD BE A PART OF THE BUSTLETON MURAL NETWORK.

PRIORITY
Medium

COST
\$ - \$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Long

ENTITIES
**City of Philadelphia
dept of Human Services**

- + The William Penn Foundation
- + City of Philadelphia
- + Local businesses
- + Commercial Property owners
- + Mural Arts

Pennypack Park is one of Philadelphia's most significant natural assets—a nine-mile greenway stretching from Montgomery County to the Delaware River, with a rich network of trails, waterways, and wooded corridors. For Bustleton residents, it is also practically in their backyard. Yet despite this geographic proximity, the park remains functionally disconnected from everyday neighborhood life. Poor pedestrian infrastructure, an absence of clearly marked entry points, and a lack of safe crossings along the park's northern edge mean that most residents drive to access a resource they could otherwise reach on foot.

This strategy centers on changing that relationship—making Pennypack Park a genuine extension of Bustleton's public life rather than a destination that requires a car. The centerpiece of this effort is the creation of a welcoming, clearly designed gateway at Bustleton Avenue and Winchester Avenue, establishing a front door to the park from the neighborhood's primary commercial corridor. Supporting investments in sidewalk connectivity and community stewardship would reinforce this gateway, ensuring that the route to the park is safe, legible, and well-maintained year-round. Together, these recommendations would support residents' physical health, strengthen the neighborhood's connection to its most significant natural resource, and give Bustleton Avenue an anchor destination at its southern end which would be great Bustleton Avenue's local businesses as well.

Recommendation 8.1: Extend Sidewalks

Recommendation 8.2: Create a "Gateway" to Bustleton

Recommendation 8.3: Encourage Neighborhood Park Clean-up Days

Recommendation 8.1

Extend Sidewalks

For a gateway to function as an inviting entry point, the pedestrian route leading to it must be safe and continuous. Currently, sidewalk coverage along the streets connecting Bustleton Avenue to Pennypack Park—particularly along Winchester Avenue approaching the park's edge—is incomplete, forcing pedestrians to walk in the roadway or navigate unpaved shoulders. This work should be coordinated with the sidewalk gap-filling effort proposed in Recommendation 1.4 to ensure a consistent approach to pedestrian infrastructure across the corridor.

All new sidewalk sections should meet ADA standards, including curb cuts and detectable warning surfaces at crossings, given that Bustleton's large and growing aging population will be among the primary users of this route. The Streets Department and OTIS are the primary implementing entities, with Philadelphia Parks & Recreation playing a coordination role given the route's terminus at park land. The planning phase would require a complete mapping the pedestrian route to reach the entrance at Bustleton Ave and Winchester Ave. Installing interim wayfinding signage along the route during construction to maintain pedestrian awareness of the future connection, can aid in actively engaging the community.

PRIORITY
High

COST
\$\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short

ENTITIES
Streets dept
+ OTIS
+ Philadelphia Parks & Recreation

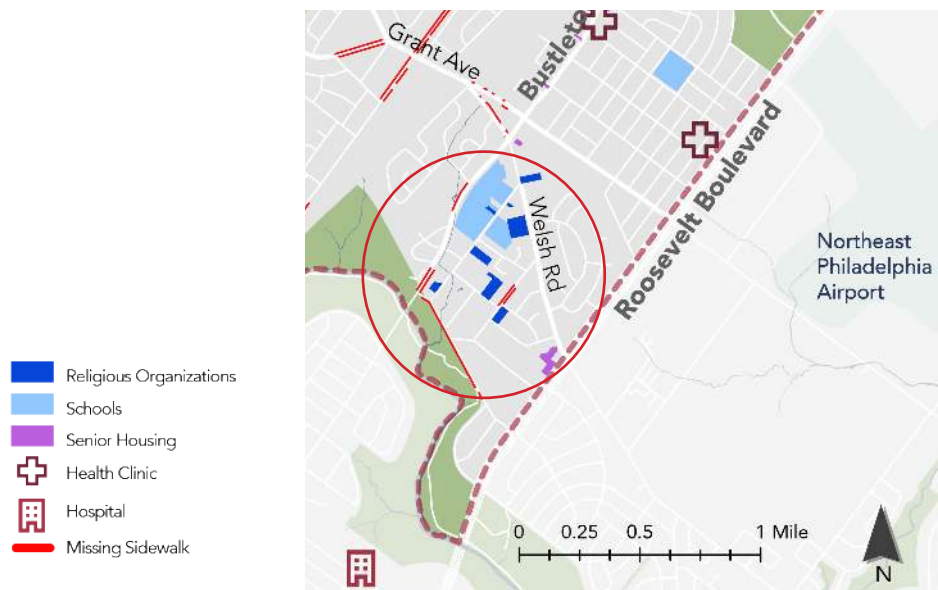


FIG.76 INCONSISTENT SIDEWALK NETWORK FROM BUSTLETON AVE TO THE PENNYPACK PARK.

PRIORITY
High

COST
\$\$\$

GOALS
1 2

TIMELINE
Mid

ENTITIES
Streets dept
+ OTIS
+ Philadelphia Parks & Recreation
+ Fairmount Park Conservancy

Recommendation 8.2

Create a Gateway in Pennypack Park from Bustleton Avenue

The intersection of Bustleton Avenue and Winchester Avenue is the natural front door between the neighborhood's commercial corridor and Pennypack Park. Right now, nothing about that intersection communicates this. There is no signage, no improved crossing, no landscaping, no sense of arrival. This recommendation proposes to change that, transforming the Bustleton Avenue and Winchester Avenue intersection into a legible, welcoming, and memorable gateway into Pennypack Park.

Philadelphia Parks & Recreation would be the primary implementing entity, in coordination with the Streets Department for any work within the right-of-way and the Fairmount Park Conservancy, which has a long track record of stewarding capital improvements across the Fairmount Park system including Pennypack. Identify funding through the DVRPC Regional Trails Program, Philadelphia Parks & Recreation capital budget, and/or the Fairmount Park Conservancy's grant programs. The initial phase also involves public engagement to identify relevant languages, and desired amenities.

CASE STUDY

Bartram's Mile Trail Gateway

Southwest Philadelphia, PA
Completed: 2019
Entity: Philadelphia Parks & Recreation



Description: Bartram's Mile offers Philadelphia's most instructive neighborhood-scale example of how a thoughtfully designed trail gateway can transform a park's relationship with its surrounding community. A new trail and gateway connection along the Schuylkill River, developed through an intensive community engagement process, created a direct, welcoming pedestrian link between the neighborhood and the waterfront.

Lesson for Bustleton: The gateway design was deliberately neighborhood-scaled: it did not require a large capital outlay, but instead focused on clear entry points, improved lighting, community-designed signage, and a well-surfaced trail connecting the street edge to the park's interior.

FIG.77 GATEWAY CONNECTION
ALONG THE SCHUYLKILL RIVER,
CREDIT: WHYY.

Recommendation 8.3

Encourage Neighborhood Park Clean-up Days

Infrastructure investments alone do not sustain a park's relationship with its community. Regular stewardship, neighbors taking collective ownership of their green spaces, is what keeps parks clean, safe, and socially alive between capital improvement cycles. Pennypack Park's trails and entry points will only remain welcoming if the community feels a sense of ongoing responsibility for them. Organized neighborhood park clean-up days are one of the most effective and lowest-cost tools available to build that culture of stewardship.

The plan recommends establishing a recurring series of community clean-up days focused on Pennypack Park's Bustleton-facing edge, particularly the trails and entry areas accessible from Winchester Avenue, organized through the Greater Bustleton Civic League in partnership with Philadelphia Parks & Recreation and the Fairmount Park Conservancy. The Pennypack Environmental Center, which already serves as a community hub within the park, is a natural anchor for this programming. The Fairmount Park Conservancy's existing volunteer and stewardship programs, as well as the Pennypack Environmental Center's community programming infrastructure, provide ready-made platforms through which this recommendation can be launched quickly and at minimal cost.



FIG.78 FRIENDS OF PENNYPACK PARK VOLUNTEER, CREDIT: NORTHEAST TIMES



FIG.79 TRASH BUSTLETON STUDIO GROUP IN PENNYPACK PARK DURING SITE VISIT

PRIORITY
Low

COST
\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Recurring

ENTITIES
**Philadelphia
Parks &
Recreation**

+ Fairmount Park
Conservancy
+ Neighborhood
Associations
+ Pennypack
Environmental Center

Establishing a Community Development Corporation (CDC) in Bustleton would provide the neighborhood with a dedicated entity to coordinate economic development, housing initiatives, and community engagement. Currently, Bustleton lacks a centralized organization focused specifically on long-term planning and implementation, which limits its ability to attract funding, manage revitalization projects, and advocate effectively for residents and businesses. A CDC could fill this gap by serving as a liaison between residents, local businesses, and the City of Philadelphia, while also pursuing grants and partnerships to support neighborhood improvements.

In practice, a Bustleton CDC could take on responsibilities such as managing corridor revitalization efforts along Bustleton Avenue, supporting small business development, and overseeing affordable housing initiatives. The organization could also lead community outreach efforts to ensure that planning decisions reflect local needs, particularly in a diverse neighborhood with a growing immigrant population. Over time, the CDC would build institutional capacity and help ensure that revitalization efforts are sustained, coordinated, and equitable.

A CDC needs 501(c)3 status, a board of directors, and an executive director. To establish this first phase, we recommend bringing together the prime community groups in the area, including the Greater Bustleton Civic Association, the New World Association, District 10 Councilmember Brian J. O'Neill, and the Far Northeast Philadelphia District Planner, in consultation with the PACDC. This group could come together to discuss the benefits of a community development corporation in Philly's Far Northeast, discuss representation on a board, and who would provide leadership to the new organization.



FIG.80 MAYOR PARKER AND THE GBCL, CREDIT: MAYOR PARKER'S INSTAGRAM



FIG.81 THE OFFICES OF THE NEW WORLD ASSOCIATION

PRIORITY
High

COST
\$

GOALS



TIMELINE
Short

ENTITIES

+ Greater Bustleton
Civic League
+ Bustleton Neighbors
Association
+ New World
Association
+ Kleinlife
+ Philadelphia
Association of
Community
Development Corps